



SPACE CHALLENGES PROGRAM 2026

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# TECHNICAL DESIGN DOCUMENT

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## Armonia

*A Three-Axis Reaction-Wheel Balancing Cube*

### PROJECT TEAM

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# 1 Introduction

## 1.1 Background & Problem Statement

The Cubli is a reaction-wheel inverted pendulum: a cube-shaped platform that balances on an edge or a corner using only internal actuation, with no external supports or contact forces beyond the single line or point of contact with the ground. The concept was introduced by the Institute for Dynamic Systems and Control (IDSC) at ETH Zurich [1, 2], whose original prototype ( $15 \times 15 \times 15$  cm) mounts one brushless DC motor and flywheel on each of three orthogonal faces. Commanding a change in wheel speed produces, by conservation of angular momentum, an equal and opposite reaction torque on the cube body; braking a wheel abruptly transfers its stored angular momentum to the body in a near-impulsive event, which is what allows the cube to *jump up* from resting on a face into a balance on an edge or corner.

Dynamically, the system is an *underactuated*, nonlinear, unstable-equilibrium control problem: three actuators (the wheels) must stabilise a body with more degrees of freedom than actuated inputs, about equilibria (edge and corner balance) that are open-loop unstable and increasingly coupled across axes as the contact geometry shrinks from a line (edge) to a point (corner). This is structurally the same problem as the classical inverted pendulum, extended from a single rotational axis to a fully three-dimensional, momentum-exchange-actuated body — which is why the Cubli has become a standard benchmark platform in the controls community over the past decade.

The problem this project addresses is therefore twofold: (i) derive and validate a dynamic model and controller capable of stabilising this underactuated system about its unstable equilibria and driving it through commanded reorientations, and (ii) realise this in hardware as a modular, largely parametric design, since final actuator and sensor specifications are not yet confirmed at the time of writing. The target capability set, in order of increasing difficulty, is edge balance, corner balance, controlled rotation, and walking (Section 1.3).

No single subsystem is exotic, but each sits close to a physical bound, and the bounds are coupled: relieving one tightens another. Four constraints drive the design, and sizing is therefore treated as the first engineering activity rather than a detail settled once parts arrive.

- **The jump-up has no energy margin.** The required per-wheel inertia scales as  $ML^{3/2}$  (Section 4.1.1), so mass added anywhere demands a larger wheel, and the wheel is itself part of  $M$ . Sizing is a fixed-point iteration, not a one-pass calculation.
- **Braking torque fights the structure.** Momentum accumulated over seconds of spin-up is shed in tens of milliseconds, through one shaft, hub and motor mount — the parts the mass budget wants thin. The structural load case is set by the manoeuvre that proves the machine works.
- **Sensing, not the control law, sets the balancing limit.** Gyroscope bias drifts, and the accelerometer — the only absolute tilt reference — is corrupted by vibration the controller itself generates. Wheel balance is therefore an estimation requirement, not a mechanical nicety.
- **The plant is nonlinear and constrained.** Corner balancing does not decouple into three single-axis problems: the axes are coupled through the contact point and the inertia tensor. The actuators saturate in both torque and speed, so stored momentum must be actively managed. Linearising about upright is adequate for balancing and inadequate for anything more [3].

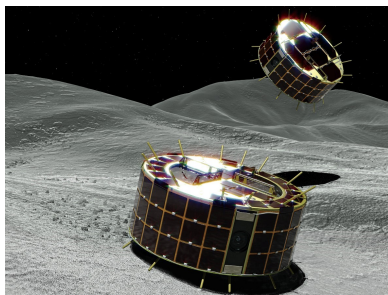
## 1.2 Purpose, Application & Mission Context

The Cubli is not presented here as a balancing novelty but as a terrestrial, gravity-loaded demonstrator of **momentum-exchange attitude control** — the same physical mechanism that governs how real spacecraft point themselves. Nearly every three-axis-stabilised satellite holds and changes its attitude using reaction wheels: flywheels whose commanded speed change produces a reaction torque on the spacecraft body, exactly as in the Cubli. Spacecraft typically carry three or four such wheels (often in a pyramidal arrangement for redundancy) — directly analogous to the Cubli’s three orthogonal wheels — and this reaction-wheel approach is the standard for CubeSats and small satellites in particular, making the Cubli representative of a real, currently-flown hardware class rather than an idealized toy problem.

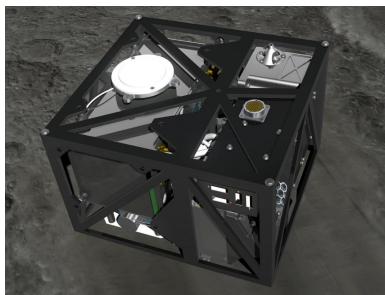
Reaction wheels are the actuator choice made here, and the alternative is worth stating explicitly because it is the standard smallsat comparison. Since this is a proof-of-concept demonstration of the control loop, a system actuated with orthogonal reaction wheels is well-suited to represent principles applicable to smallsat ADCS: the momentum-exchange actuation principle and closed-loop control architecture are the same as those used on real spacecraft, even though the Cubli’s dynamics (balancing against gravity) differ from a satellite’s free-fall attitude control problem. Reaction wheels are also structurally simpler and require less specialised hardware than control moment gyros, which offer higher torque density but at the cost of gimbal mechanisms and more complex control software — complexity that is typically only justified on larger spacecraft. For a low-cost, resource-limited project, a reaction-wheel Cubli therefore demonstrates the core actuation and control principles of smallsat ADCS in a practical and relevant way.

Framed as an Attitude Determination and Control System (ADCS) problem, the Cubli’s core behaviours map directly onto a spacecraft’s day-to-day pointing task:

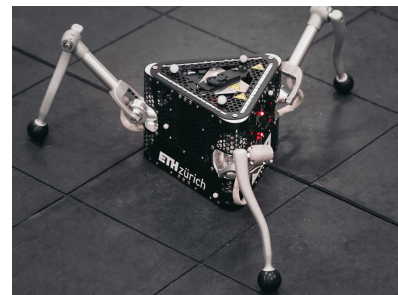
- **Edge / corner balance** → regulation to a commanded reference attitude and disturbance rejection — holding a pointing setpoint against perturbations.
- **Controlled rotation** → a slew manoeuvre: reference tracking to a new commanded attitude, exactly as a satellite re-aims a payload or antenna.
- **Jump / walk** → momentum-exchange hopping mobility, flight-proven on small bodies where wheeled traction is impossible (Figure 1). Walking, as a sequence of controlled directional hops, extends single-hop capabilities and represents an active research frontier (Section 1.3).



(a) MINERVA-II1



(b) MASCOT



(c) SpaceHopper

**Figure 1:** Momentum-exchange actuation in flight and research hardware: (a) JAXA’s MINERVA-II1 rovers [4] and (b) the MASCOT lander [5], deployed by Hayabusa2 onto asteroid Ryugu (2018), hop across the surface and self-right by spinning up and braking an internal flywheel or eccentric mass; (c) ETH Zurich’s SpaceHopper [6] extends this principle to controlled, directional hopping in low gravity.

The subsystem exercised here is therefore the one a spacecraft uses for pointing: momentum-exchange attitude control under actuator saturation, with desaturation, on an underactuated



body whose inertia is imperfectly known. Under gravity the destabilising torque never relents, so an inadequate controller falls over immediately and unambiguously — the demonstration is self-evaluating, which a free-fall attitude testbed is not.

The nominal Cubli problem was solved a decade ago on precisely manufactured hardware [1, 2, 3]; reproducing it is an engineering exercise, and this document claims no more. A commodity build is adopted for three reasons. It can be crashed repeatedly, so the controller can be tested at its limits; its loose tolerances, imperfectly balanced wheels and drifting IMU supply the parameter uncertainty that robust control methods are intended to tolerate; and a fixed motor, print volume and budget constrain the sizing, since a marginal design cannot be rescued by specifying a larger component. The last of these motivates the adjustable ballast scheme of Section 4.3.

### 1.3 Objectives

Each project objective imposes a required capability. The mapping below keeps every requirement traceable from motivation to capability, and is what the sizing and control work below must be shown to satisfy.

**Table 1:** Objective-to-requirement traceability.

| Objective           | Required capability                                                                                                                       |
|---------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Edge balance        | The system must actively maintain dynamic stability and regulate its posture about a single line-contact equilibrium position.            |
| Corner balance      | The system must maintain multi-axis closed-loop balance and attitude control around a highly unstable point-contact equilibrium.          |
| Controlled rotation | The controller must accurately track dynamic reference trajectories to execute smooth slew maneuvers between distinct equilibrium states. |
| Walking (stretch)   | The system must execute a sequential series of dynamic jump-up maneuvers and rapidly re-stabilize itself upon each landing impact.        |

These map one-to-one onto the applications of Section 1.2: (1)–(2) demonstrate pointing regulation and disturbance rejection of increasing difficulty; (3) demonstrates slew/reference-tracking; (4) demonstrates momentum-exchange mobility of the kind flown on Hayabusa2. Milestones (1)–(3) are treated as committed deliverables for this design; walking (4) is scoped as the stretch objective, contingent on hardware confirmation and the jump-up feasibility check (angular momentum required to tip the cube vs. available motor/wheel torque), to be resolved once final components are known.

## 2 Project Organisation

### 2.1 Team Organisation

The project is developed by a multidisciplinary team, with responsibilities distributed across the main technical domains of the Cubli: mathematical modelling, control, embedded software, mechanical and three-dimensional design, electrical build, and system integration and validation. Table 2 states each member’s role and the scope they are accountable for.

**Table 2:** Team members, contact details and primary roles.

| Member                | Contact                                                                                          | Role and accountable scope                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Pablo Urioste Alarcón | <a href="mailto:pb.urioste4@gmail.com">pb.urioste4@gmail.com</a><br>+34 654 491 174              | <b>Project management and hardware-facing software.</b> Schedule, gate criteria and task allocation; motor-driver configuration, the flight-computer-driver link, the sensor drivers and their calibration, and the fixed-rate loop that carries them. Owns the hardware-software seam. Assembles and edits this document.      |
| Deyan Nikolaev Vlaev  | <a href="mailto:vlaev.dido@gmail.com">vlaev.dido@gmail.com</a><br>+359 877 082 499               | <b>Dynamics and technical documentation.</b> Equations of motion, linearisation and jump-up energy sizing; drafting and deepening of this document against the model.                                                                                                                                                           |
| Niccolo Tonetto       | <a href="mailto:niccolo.tonetto@gmail.com">niccolo.tonetto@gmail.com</a>                         | <b>Control stack and build support.</b> Single owner of the control and estimation software — estimator, safety and mode logic, and the consolidated control release — written against the sensor interface Pablo maintains. Fabricates the distribution board and cube harness; leads the sacrificial brake and jump-up scope. |
| Andrea Liang          | <a href="mailto:andrea.liang.2006@gmail.com">andrea.liang.2006@gmail.com</a><br>+31 06 5796 2976 | <b>Plant identification and control design.</b> Sizing calculations and the inertia and control budgets; sole owner of rig parameter measurement, from the instrumented measurement through to the validated plant model the balancing controllers are designed on.                                                             |
| Suvanna Viriyanti Wu  | <a href="mailto:Viriyanti.wu@gmail.com">Viriyanti.wu@gmail.com</a><br>+39 329 074 7550           | <b>1-DoF model and mechanical build.</b> Builds and iterates the single-axis prototype and its testbench, fabricates the reaction wheels, and supports the 3D design work.                                                                                                                                                      |
| Athanasia Nikolova    | <a href="mailto:nasia.nikolova@mtel.gr">nasia.nikolova@mtel.gr</a>                               | <b>3D design and commercialisation.</b> 3D CAD, frame design and mechanical enclosures; monitors the design against the frozen mass and interface constraints; prototype assembly and the commercial pitch.                                                                                                                     |

### 2.2 Work Breakdown Structure

This plan runs from project start to the final presentation on 20 August 2026. The work is grouped into five streams — investigation, requirements and documentation; control and software; hardware design and build; three-dimensional design; and electrical and electronics — led by the owners assigned in Table 2. The investigation is kept to the essentials needed to substantiate the design: a focused literature review, the dynamics derivation, and the wheel sizing that follows from it. Table 3 breaks the streams into individual tasks, each with its scope, single accountable lead and dates.

**Table 3:** Work breakdown structure, broken into individual tasks with scope, lead and dates, grouped by workstream.

| ID                                                     | Task                              | Scope                                                                                                                                   | Lead    | Dates        |
|--------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------|--------------|
| <b>Investigation, Requirements &amp; Documentation</b> |                                   |                                                                                                                                         |         |              |
| A1                                                     | Literature & state of the art     | Review the ETH Cubli, the one-wheel Cubli, CubeSat ADCS practice and the hopping-mission precedents                                     | Suvanna | 23–25 Jul    |
| A2                                                     | Problem statement & framing       | Lock the ADCS application narrative that the rest of the document refers back to                                                        | Pablo   | 23–24 Jul    |
| A3                                                     | Scope & requirements              | Define scope and build the requirements table (functional, performance, design constraint) with verification methods                    | Pablo   | 24–25 Jul    |
| A4                                                     | Milestones & roles                | Prototype staging, binary gate criteria, and a one-page RACI of owners                                                                  | Pablo   | 23–25 Jul    |
| A5                                                     | Risk register                     | Trigger, impact, owner and mitigation for the leading risks                                                                             | Pablo   | 28–29 Jul    |
| A6                                                     | 1-DoF equations of motion         | Lagrangian derivation of the reaction-wheel pendulum with friction terms                                                                | Deyan   | 24–25 Jul    |
| A7                                                     | 3D equations of motion            | Coupled three-wheel dynamics for the edge and corner pivots                                                                             | Deyan   | 27–28 Jul    |
| A8                                                     | Linearisation & controllability   | Equilibria, linear models, controllability/observability checks                                                                         | Deyan   | 29–31 Jul    |
| A9                                                     | Jump-up sizing & budget           | Energy-method wheel sizing and the parametric mass/inertia/CoM budget                                                                   | Deyan   | 30 Jul–2 Aug |
| A10                                                    | TDD draft (all sections)          | Every member drafts their own section; placeholder figures acceptable                                                                   | Deyan   | 25–28 Jul    |
| A11                                                    | TDD deepen + rig evidence         | Modelling and control sections in full, with the rig evidence and measured parameters available at the time of writing                  | Deyan   | 29 Jul–2 Aug |
| A12                                                    | TDD v1 assemble & submit          | Consistency pass, figures, references, submission of the first assessed deliverable                                                     | Pablo   | 3 Aug        |
| A13                                                    | Assessor feedback triage          | Triage the v1 assessment, assign each comment to an owner, and re-baseline roles and task allocation for v2                             | Pablo   | 4–7 Aug      |
| A14                                                    | TDD v2 corrections & second draft | Address the assessor comments and fold in the build, bring-up and test results since v1. Ends 12 Aug: no work 13 Aug                    | Pablo   | 8–12 Aug     |
| A15                                                    | TDD v2 final submission           | Final consistency pass and submission of the corrected document                                                                         | Pablo   | 14 Aug       |
| <b>Control &amp; Software</b>                          |                                   |                                                                                                                                         |         |              |
| B1                                                     | Sim environment + plant           | Simulation setup and the 1-DoF plant, validated by energy conservation                                                                  | Andrea  | 23 Jul–3 Aug |
| B2                                                     | LQR design (1-DoF, sim)           | Tune the regulator and sweep robustness to inertia error, delay and saturation                                                          | Andrea  | 26 Jul–6 Aug |
| B3                                                     | State estimator                   | Complementary tilt filter, tested against injected noise and bias                                                                       | Niccolo | 27 Jul–7 Aug |
| B3b                                                    | Software interface contract       | Fix the sensor and command structs passed between the sensor loop and the controller, with the units and sign convention of every field | Pablo   | 3–4 Aug      |

| ID                                 | Task                          | Scope                                                                                                                          | Lead    | Dates        |
|------------------------------------|-------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------|--------------|
| B4                                 | Flight computer & comms       | Teensy 4.1 architecture, loop rates, driver configuration and the CAN-FD command/reply protocol                                | Pablo   | 24 Jul–7 Aug |
| B5                                 | Sensor drivers + cal          | IMU and encoder drivers, gyro/accel calibration and the lever-arm correction                                                   | Pablo   | 28 Jul–7 Aug |
| B6                                 | Safety & mode logic           | Watchdog, tilt-limit disarm, wheel-speed cap and the mode state machine                                                        | Niccolo | 30 Jul–7 Aug |
| B7                                 | 1-DoF control design complete | Consolidated 1-DoF control stack — plant, regulator, estimator and safety logic — released as the rig baseline                 | Niccolo | 8–9 Aug      |
| B8                                 | System identification         | Measure $K_t$ , wheel inertia, friction and loop latency on the rig. Single owner with E6                                      | Andrea  | 7–9 Aug      |
| B9                                 | 3D model + LQR (sim)          | 3D plant and the edge/corner regulators with the CAD inertia tensor                                                            | Andrea  | 10–14 Aug    |
| B10                                | EKF / MEKF estimator          | 3D estimator with gyro-bias states; characterise the yaw drift                                                                 | Niccolo | 12–15 Aug    |
| B11                                | Edge balance (S2a)            | Retune the edge controller on the assembled cube; log disturbance recovery                                                     | Andrea  | 15–17 Aug    |
| B12                                | Corner balance + slew (S2b/c) | Coupled three-axis corner balance and a commanded slew; report ADCS metrics                                                    | Andrea  | 17–19 Aug    |
| B13                                | Jump-up (S3)                  | Spin-up profile and brake release for a face-to-edge jump. Sacrificial scope: yields to G6 and G7 if the schedule is contested | Niccolo | 19–20 Aug    |
| <b>Hardware Design &amp; Build</b> |                               |                                                                                                                                |         |              |
| C1                                 | Envelope & layout study       | Packaging of wheels, drivers, battery and electronics with a central CoM                                                       | Nasia   | 23–24 Jul    |
| C2                                 | Reaction-wheel design         | Wheel to the inertia target: radius, rim, hub bolting to the motor bell                                                        | Suvanna | 24–26 Jul    |
| C3                                 | Mounts & brackets             | Motor mount, ring-magnet carrier and adjustable encoder bracket                                                                | Nasia   | 27–29 Jul    |
| C4                                 | 1-DoF rig CAD + jigs          | Single-axis rig and the balancing/assembly tooling                                                                             | Suvanna | 25–28 Jul    |
| C6                                 | Procurement order (round 1)   | Order the long-lead items (rims, frame stock, connectors, spares)                                                              | Pablo   | 23–24 Jul    |
| C7                                 | Bench PSU & bring-up          | Current-limited supply, safety kit, and single-axis electrical bring-up                                                        | Pablo   | 25–27 Jul    |
| C8                                 | Fabricate wheel rings         | Print the PET-CF rings and hubs to the frozen wheel geometry                                                                   | Suvanna | 27 Jul–2 Aug |
| C8b                                | Wheel ballast & completion    | Install the M6 bolt/nut ballast stations to the sizing specification and complete each wheel                                   | Suvanna | 4–6 Aug      |
| C9                                 | Balance & spin-test           | Static-balance and containment spin-test every wheel, including a per-wheel ballast-count verification                         | Suvanna | 5–6 Aug      |
| C10                                | Assemble 1-DoF rig            | Motor, balanced wheel, encoder gap, IMU and hard stops, on reinforced rig supports                                             | Pablo   | 31 Jul–2 Aug |
| C11                                | Print structure + frame       | Structural print set and the fabricated, orthogonal frame                                                                      | Suvanna | 8–12 Aug     |

| ID                                  | Task                             | Scope                                                                                                                                                                                                      | Lead    | Dates        |
|-------------------------------------|----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------|--------------|
| C12                                 | Perfboard + harness              | Power/signal board and the full power and CAN harness                                                                                                                                                      | Pablo   | 8–12 Aug     |
| C13                                 | Cube integration + power-on      | Assemble the three axes, then bench and battery smoke test                                                                                                                                                 | Pablo   | 13–15 Aug    |
| C14                                 | Brake mechanism build            | Fabricate and fit the three servo brakes; bench-test the deceleration                                                                                                                                      | Suvanna | 15–18 Aug    |
| <b>3D Design</b>                    |                                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                            |         |              |
| D1                                  | Concept sizing & fit study       | Confirm that every component fits the 150 mm envelope and lay out the internal structure                                                                                                                   | Nasia   | 27 Jul–2 Aug |
| D2                                  | Frame design freeze              | Freeze the inertia-bearing frame geometry. Later features that do not affect the mass properties may still be added                                                                                        | Nasia   | 2 Aug        |
| D3                                  | Mass properties & budget closure | Export the inertia tensor and CoM and close the mass budget against the sizing analysis                                                                                                                    | Nasia   | 3–4 Aug      |
| D4                                  | Detail CAD                       | Brackets, electronics bay, harness routing and the electrical keep-outs to the frozen board outline                                                                                                        | Suvanna | 3–5 Aug      |
| D5                                  | Procurement order (round 2)      | Consolidate the bill of materials arising from the 3D design and place the second order                                                                                                                    | Pablo   | 5 Aug        |
| D6                                  | Tolerance & clearance analysis   | Fit and tolerance study, including the wheel sweep envelope and fastener access                                                                                                                            | Nasia   | 5–6 Aug      |
| D7                                  | Manufacturing package release    | Issue the drawings, print set and assembly instructions for fabrication                                                                                                                                    | Nasia   | 7 Aug        |
| <b>Electrical &amp; Electronics</b> |                                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                            |         |              |
| E1                                  | Wiring & placement design        | Electrical architecture, wiring scheme and component placement for the single-axis rig, issued as the build reference                                                                                      | Pablo   | 28–31 Jul    |
| E2                                  | Rail, driver & encoder bring-up  | 5 V rail soldered and trimmed to 5.00 V under load; driver phase-wired and FOC-calibrated; MA600 encoder mounted at $\leq 0.5$ mm air gap with verified read-back. Open-loop operation on the bench supply | Pablo   | 1–3 Aug      |
| E3                                  | Rig bus & sensor integration     | Two-node CAN-FD bus with split termination at both physical ends, Teensy and IMU integrated on the rig harness                                                                                             | Pablo   | 4–5 Aug      |
| E4                                  | Board outline & floorplan        | Driver placement from the encoder cable limit, CAN routing, and the perfboard floorplan issued as a frozen outline to CAD                                                                                  | Pablo   | 4–5 Aug      |
| E5                                  | 1-DoF closed-loop bring-up       | Closed loop on the rig with the disarm path and watchdog verified before any balance attempt                                                                                                               | Pablo   | 6–7 Aug      |
| E6                                  | Rig parameter measurement        | Instrumented measurement of $K_t$ , wheel inertia, friction and loop latency. Merged with B8: one owner measures and models                                                                                | Andrea  | 7–9 Aug      |

| ID                  | Task                                        | Scope                                                                                                                                                                                                                | Lead    | Dates     |
|---------------------|---------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------|-----------|
| E6b                 | Mechanical & performance validation (1-DoF) | Reconcile the measured torque, inertia, friction and achievable momentum against the jump-up sizing (A9). Deviation beyond tolerance forces a re-sizing decision that day, while the wheel geometry can still change | Andrea  | 9 Aug     |
| E7                  | Perfboard + battery power chain             | Populate the distribution perfboard (two ground domains, one star point, split 5 V rail); XT60 chain with anti-spark, fuse and $\geq 50$ V bulk capacitance; replicate the remaining actuation sets                  | Niccolo | 8–11 Aug  |
| E8                  | 4-node bus + cube harness                   | Bus scaled to four nodes with stubs $< 10$ cm and an error soak at 5 Mbit/s; full power and signal harness fabricated and routed; Wi-Fi telemetry for untethered operation                                           | Niccolo | 11–12 Aug |
| E9                  | Cube power-on, 48 A + thermal               | First battery power-on and the three-axis 48 A transient; driver thermals in the enclosed volume; all axes addressable                                                                                               | Pablo   | 14–15 Aug |
| E10                 | Brake servo rail + measurement              | Servo on an isolated 5 V rail with PWM drive and flyback; rail stability under stall, brake closure time and spin-down brake torque measured. Sacrificial with C14/B13                                               | Niccolo | 16–19 Aug |
| <b>Deliverables</b> |                                             |                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |         |           |
| F1                  | Results, demo & final presentation          | Slow-motion capture, results plots, deck, and the final presentation                                                                                                                                                 | Andrea  | 18–20 Aug |

## 2.3 Schedule and Contingency Plan

The full-page schedule in Figure 2 places every task of Section 2.2 on the 23 July–20 August 2026 calendar, and Table 4 states the gate that closes each phase.

**Structure of the plan.** The first two weeks establish the analytical and design foundation: the dynamics derivation and wheel sizing on the documentation side, the single-axis rig and its wiring design on the hardware and electrical sides, and the simulation environment on the control side. These converge on 2 August, which carries two objectives: the first powered bring-up of the single-axis rig, taking the 5 V rail, the driver and the encoder to verified open-loop operation (M1); and the freeze of the three-dimensional frame geometry, which closes the mass and inertia budget against the sizing analysis (M2). The frame freeze releases the second procurement round on 5 August (M3), which is the last point at which parts can be ordered with useful delivery margin before cube assembly begins on 13 August.

The documentation stream carries two assessed submissions. The first is delivered on 3 August (G4) with the evidence available at that date; the assessor’s comments are triaged during the following week and the corrected second draft is submitted on 14 August (M8), by which point the rig results and the integrated cube can both be reported.

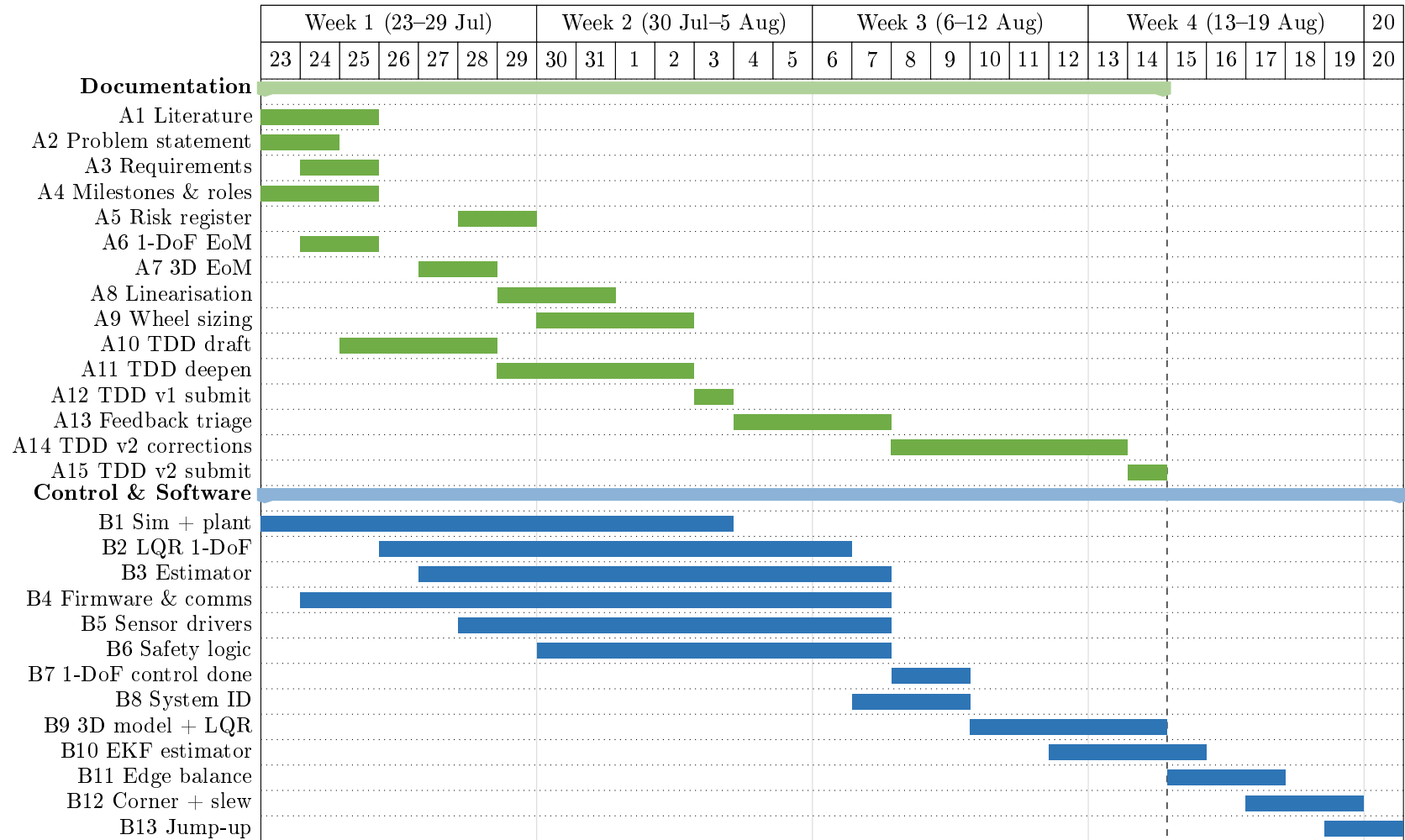
**Critical path and contingency.** The critical path runs from the 2 August bring-up through the closed-loop rig (M4), the measured plant parameters (M6) and the single-axis control design (M7), into the three-dimensional controller and the balancing demonstrations. The single-axis

rig is the protected item, since its balance result is the experimental evidence in the document. The three-dimensional design proceeds in parallel on the mechanical side, so that fabrication is not held by the control work.

The plan carries the full scope through to the jump-up demonstration. The final week is nonetheless tightly constrained: edge balance begins two days after cube assembly completes, and the jump-up gate falls on the day of the final presentation. The jump-up (S3) is therefore designated sacrificial scope by standing decision. If the balancing demonstrations require the time, the jump-up yields first, and the demonstration presented on 20 August is the corner balance and commanded slew. The brake mechanism build and its associated electrical work are sequenced after the edge-balance gate for the same reason.

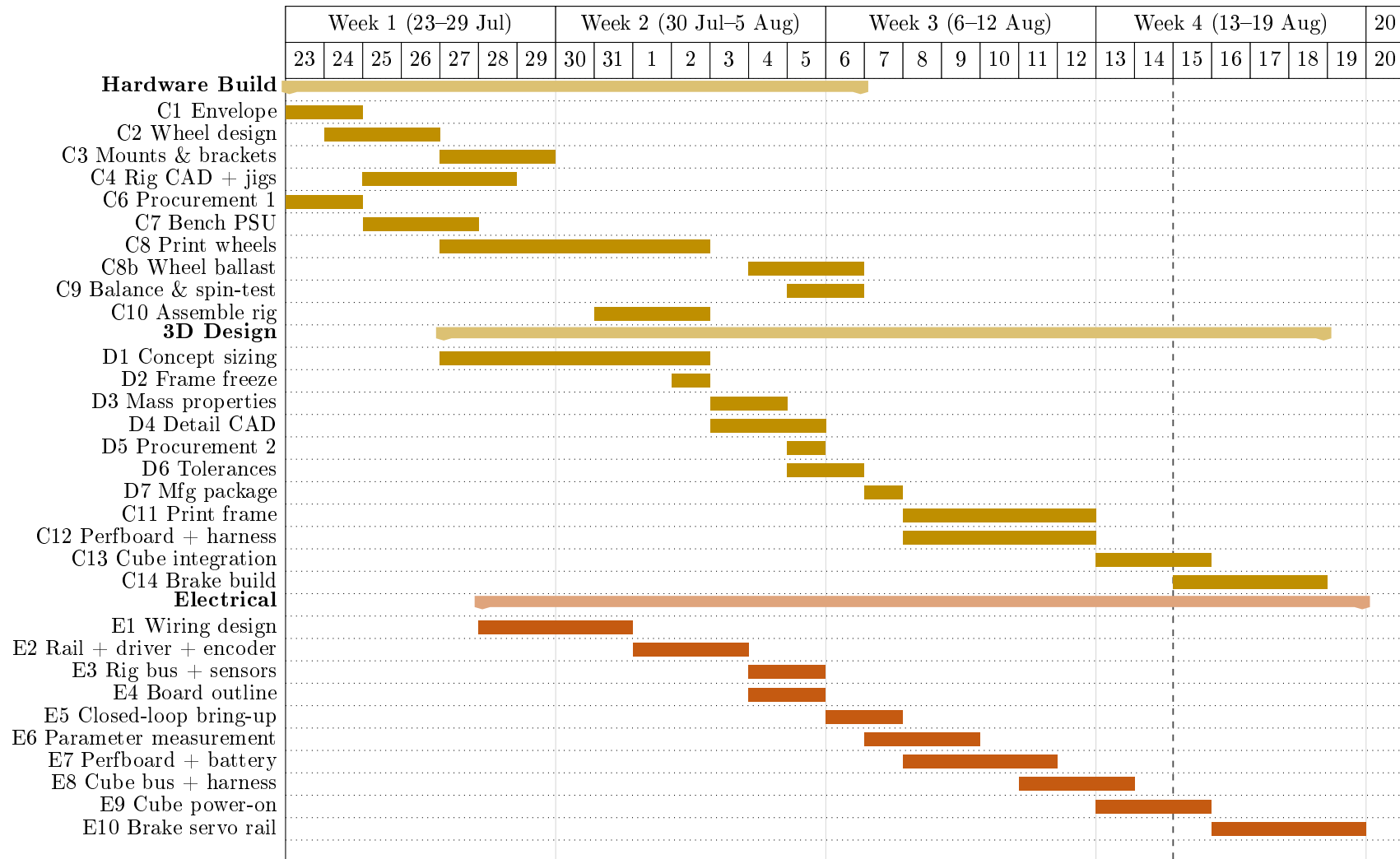
**Table 4:** Milestone gates, from kick-off to the final presentation, with the criterion that closes each one.

| Gate | Pass criterion                                                                                                                                                                     | Date   |
|------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|
| G1   | Long-lead order placed; requirements and plan locked                                                                                                                               | 24 Jul |
| G2   | Dynamics, linearisation and wheel sizing complete                                                                                                                                  | 31 Jul |
| M1   | 1-DoF rig bring-up: 5 V rail trimmed under load, driver commutating, encoder verified at $\leq 0.5$ mm gap                                                                         | 2 Aug  |
| M2   | 3D frame geometry frozen at 150 mm; mass, inertia and CoM budget closed against the sizing analysis                                                                                | 2 Aug  |
| G4   | TDD v1 delivered for assessment                                                                                                                                                    | 3 Aug  |
| M3   | Procurement round 2 consolidated and ordered                                                                                                                                       | 5 Aug  |
| M4   | 1-DoF closed loop live; disarm path and watchdog verified                                                                                                                          | 7 Aug  |
| M5   | Manufacturing package released for fabrication                                                                                                                                     | 7 Aug  |
| M6   | Plant parameters measured on the rig and validated against simulation; measured torque, inertia and friction reconciled with the sizing analysis, or a re-sizing decision recorded | 9 Aug  |
| M7   | 1-DoF control design complete: plant, regulator, estimator and safety logic                                                                                                        | 9 Aug  |
| G3   | 1-DoF rig balances $\geq 60$ s unassisted                                                                                                                                          | 12 Aug |
| M8   | TDD v2 corrected and finally submitted                                                                                                                                             | 14 Aug |
| G5   | Cube integrated and powered; all axes addressable                                                                                                                                  | 15 Aug |
| G6   | Edge balance (S2a) for $\geq 60$ s with disturbance recovery                                                                                                                       | 17 Aug |
| G7   | Corner balance and commanded slew (S2b/c)                                                                                                                                          | 19 Aug |
| G8   | Face-to-edge jump-up (S3) captured on video (sacrificial scope)                                                                                                                    | 20 Aug |
| G9   | Final presentation and demonstration                                                                                                                                               | 20 Aug |

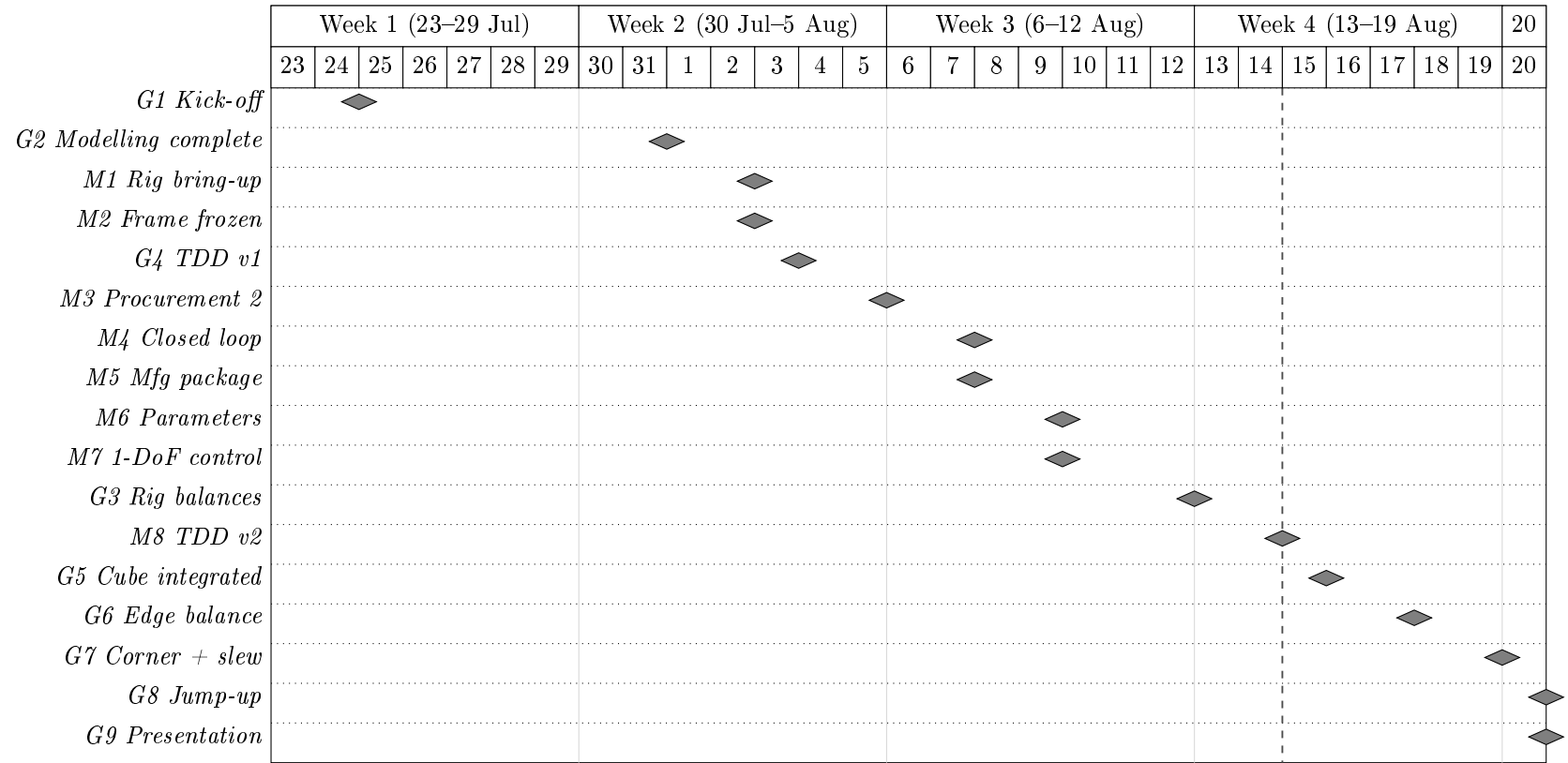


**Figure 2:** Project schedule, 23 July–20 August 2026 (sheet 1 of 3): documentation and control/software streams. The documentation stream (green) carries two assessed submissions, on 3 and 14 August. Control and software (blue) runs from the simulation environment through to the balancing demonstrations, with the three-dimensional extension concentrated in the final two weeks. The build streams continue in Figure 3 and the milestone gates in Figure 4.





**Figure 3:** Project schedule, 23 July–20 August 2026 (sheet 2 of 3): hardware, three-dimensional design, electrical and deliverable streams, continued from Figure 2. Hardware (gold) separates the single-axis build from the three-dimensional design, and the electrical stream (orange) proceeds from the single-axis bring-up to the integrated cube. The milestone gates that close each phase are shown in Figure 4.



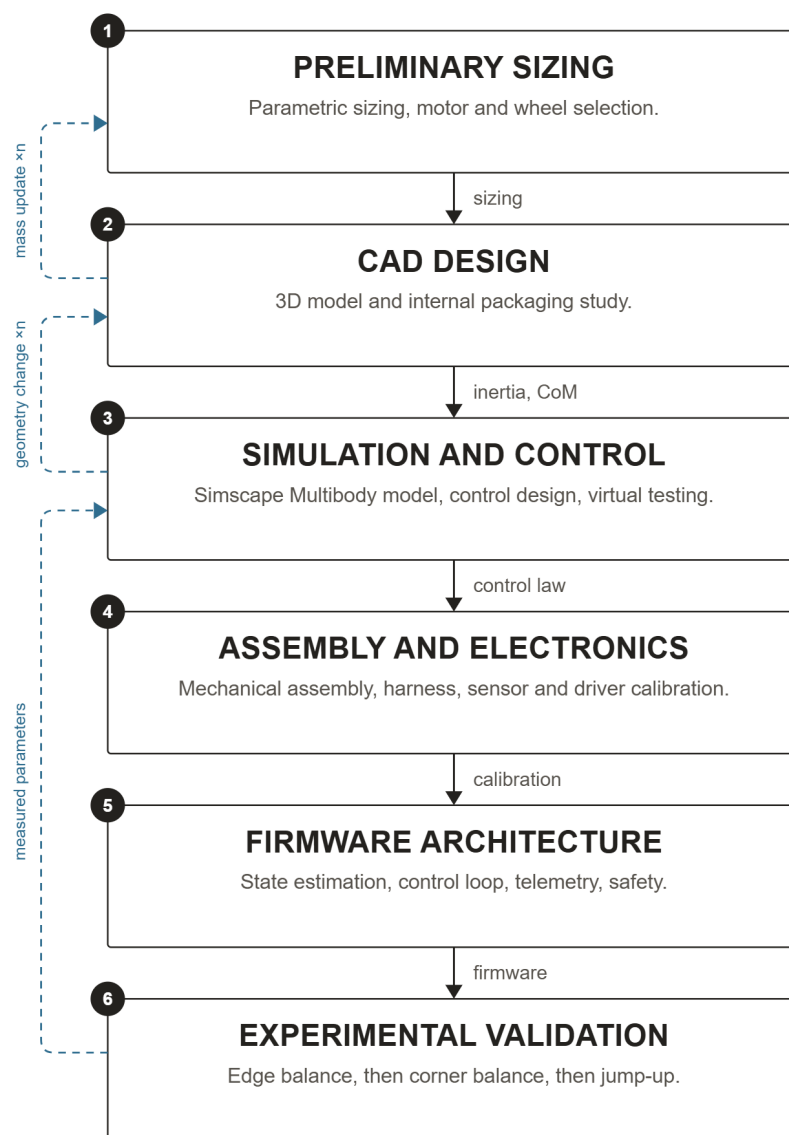
**Figure 4:** Project schedule, 23 July–20 August 2026 (sheet 3 of 3): the milestone gates that close each phase, continued from Figures 2 and 3. Grey diamonds mark the gates listed in Table 4, placed on the day each gate falls due.

### 3 Methodology

Section 2.2 assigns every task an owner and a date. This section states the reasoning that assignment is built on: the procedure the team follows to take the Cubli from a sizing target to a validated prototype, why its six stages run in this order and not another, and why the result is an iteration rather than a single pass through them. The Cubli is an interdisciplinary system whose subsystems cannot be sized, modelled or validated in isolation, which is why the methodology below is organised as a sequence of stages and validation gates rather than a single design pass.

#### 3.1 Development and Iteration Workflow

Figure 5 is that procedure: six stages, each committing an output the next stage cannot start without, and three feedback paths that reopen an earlier stage when a downstream finding invalidates an upstream assumption.



**Figure 5:** Development and iteration workflow, with the three feedback loops that keep sizing, CAD and control consistent with each other and with measured hardware.

**Workflow steps** Each stage sits where it does because the stage after it consumes an output only it produces:

1. **Preliminary Sizing** is the first stage of the project: it derives the physics behind the Cubli and justifies the design parameters and performance targets the rest of the design must meet. It fixes the cube mass, edge length and target wheel inertia before anything is drawn, because a part modelled to the wrong mass has to be redrawn no matter how well it is designed (Section 4).
2. **CAD Design** turns those targets into a 3D model and an internal packaging study, returning a measured inertia tensor and centre of mass where Stage 1 could only estimate them (Section 5).
3. **Simulation and Control** tests control feasibility against the CAD-derived inertia, mass and geometry rather than the Stage 1 estimate, since a controller tuned on the wrong inertia tensor is validated against the wrong plant (Sections 3.2–3.4, 7).
4. **Assembly and Electronics** begins once the design is closed: the cube is assembled, the electronics are placed and wired, and every axis is tested before it is commanded (Section 6).
5. **Firmware Architecture** is developed in parallel with the previous stage: it integrates the electronics around the MCU and implements the control-dynamics loop that converts IMU orientation data into wheel-torque commands. Alongside the flight code, sub-programs are developed to test and calibrate each electronic module individually (Section 7.5.2).
6. **Experimental Validation** is the last stage: once integration concludes, results are tested against the Simulink/Simscape simulation analysis, and any shortfall is traced back to the CAD design, hardware or software rather than patched locally. The workflow accommodates iteration at every stage rather than assuming a single pass succeeds (Section ??).

**Iterative loop at each stage** A single pass through that order is not sufficient, because three of its outputs correct an assumption made earlier in the same pass rather than only feeding forward:

- *Mass update.* CAD’s as-modelled mass and CoM close the loop into Stage 1’s assumed  $M$  (Section 4.2): the sizing reported there is the fixed point of this loop, not its first iteration.
- *Geometry change.* A control or simulation finding — inertia short of target, an infeasible slew, an interference the 2D model could not see — returns to CAD rather than being absorbed by re-tuning gains, since no gain fixes a wheel that does not fit or a body the controller cannot actuate against.
- *Measured parameters.* Once hardware exists, the torque constant, friction and latency measured on it (Section 3.3) replace the CAD/datasheet estimates Stage 3 was designed on, and the control gains are re-derived against the measured plant rather than flown on assumed values.

This is also why the schedule of Section 2.3 gates CAD on the sizing numbers rather than running the two in parallel: a frame frozen ahead of the inertia tensor is a frame that may have to be reprinted, which costs more than the days spent waiting on the number.

The full Cubli is underactuated and simultaneously unstable about all three axes when balanced on a corner (Section 1.3). Stage 3 of the procedure above is therefore itself incremental: a first, single-face 1-DoF prototype is built and modelled in two dimensions, so that the dynamics, the parameter identification procedure and the estimator can be validated on a plant simple enough to reason about directly; the same modelling, identification and verification workflow is then generalised to the second and final prototype, the fully three-dimensional cube, in Section 3.4. Each

subsection below states the equations that define the problem at that stage and the method used to determine every parameter that appears in them; the control law itself — how those equations are turned into a feedback command — is derived separately in Section 7, since sizing, dynamics and control are three passes over the same plant rather than three independent problems.

### 3.2 2D Reaction-Wheel Pendulum

The 1-DoF prototype is a 3D-printed plate sized to one cube face, with a motor-driven momentum wheel at its centre and a braking mechanism at one corner. The plate pivots on a bearing at that corner, constraining motion to a single rotational degree of freedom in a vertical plane.

#### 3.2.1 Equations of Motion

The nonlinear equations of motion are

$$\ddot{\theta}_b = \frac{(m_b l_b + m_w l) g \sin \theta_b - T_m - C_b \dot{\theta}_b + C_w \dot{\theta}_w}{I_b + m_w l^2}, \quad (1)$$

$$\begin{aligned} \ddot{\theta}_w = & \frac{(I_b + I_w + m_w l^2)(T_m - C_w \dot{\theta}_w)}{I_w(I_b + m_w l^2)} \\ & - \frac{(m_b l_b + m_w l) g \sin \theta_b - C_b \dot{\theta}_b}{I_b + m_w l^2}, \end{aligned} \quad (2)$$

with motor current-torque relation  $T_m = K_m u$ . Symbols are defined in Table 5 and used throughout this section.

**Table 5:** 2D pendulum model variables.

| Symbol     | Description                                          | Unit                 |
|------------|------------------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| $\theta_b$ | Body tilt angle                                      | rad                  |
| $\theta_w$ | Wheel rotation relative to body                      | rad                  |
| $m_b, m_w$ | Body, wheel mass                                     | kg                   |
| $I_b, I_w$ | Body (about pivot), wheel (about motor axis) inertia | kg m <sup>2</sup>    |
| $l$        | Motor axis to pivot distance                         | m                    |
| $l_b$      | Body CoM to pivot distance                           | m                    |
| $g$        | Gravitational acceleration                           | m/s <sup>2</sup>     |
| $T_m$      | Motor torque                                         | N m                  |
| $C_b, C_w$ | Body, wheel damping coefficient                      | kg m <sup>2</sup> /s |
| $K_m$      | Motor torque constant                                | N m/A                |
| $u$        | Motor current input                                  | A                    |

### 3.3 Parameter Identification & the 2D Testbed

CAD mass-properties simulation, accounting for print material, infill, and mounted hardware (driver, encoder, MCU, gyroscope/accelerometer, wiring), gives  $m_b, m_w, I_b, I_w$  directly, while  $l$  and  $l_b$  follow from the plate's design geometry. The damping coefficients  $C_b$  and  $C_w$  cannot be obtained from CAD, since they depend on bearing friction, wiring drag, and motor cogging; nominal values are used for the initial control design and replaced by the measured values below once the prototype is fabricated.

**Table 6:** Parameter determination method (symbols per Table 5).

| Symbol | Determination method                         |
|--------|----------------------------------------------|
| $l$    | Calculated during design                     |
| $l_b$  | Calculated during design                     |
| $m_b$  | CAD mass properties                          |
| $m_w$  | CAD mass properties                          |
| $I_b$  | CAD mass properties                          |
| $I_w$  | CAD mass properties                          |
| $C_b$  | Estimated (measured on the 1-DoF rig, below) |
| $C_w$  | Estimated (measured on the 1-DoF rig, below) |
| $K_m$  | Motor datasheet                              |

**1-DoF plant identification.** Four parameters are measured on the single-axis rig once it is built, each by a method chosen so that the quantity of interest dominates the measurement rather than appearing as a small correction to something else. These measured values replace the CAD/datasheet estimates of Table 6 before the control gains used on hardware are finalised (Section 7).

**Table 7:** Plant parameters measured on the 1-DoF rig. Expected values follow from the design point and are populated when it closes.

| Parameter                | Method                                                                        | Instrument                      | Value      |
|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|------------|
| Torque constant<br>$K_t$ | Current step against a locked rotor; torque from measured reaction            | Driver current telemetry        | <b>TBD</b> |
| Body inertia $J$         | Free-swing test about the pivot; inertia from the measured oscillation period | Encoder or IMU log              | <b>TBD</b> |
| Friction                 | Wheel coast-down from speed; viscous and Coulomb terms separated by fit       | Encoder log                     | <b>TBD</b> |
| Loop latency             | Command-to-response timestamp through the full sense–compute–actuate path     | Loopback on the flight computer | <b>TBD</b> |

Tolerances are stated with the measured values, since a parameter without a tolerance cannot support the robustness sweep of Section 7 that consumes it. Loop latency is measured through the complete path rather than estimated from the 1 kHz loop rate, because the scheduling and bus-transport contributions are the ones a rate figure omits.

### 3.4 Generalization to the 3D Cube

The dynamics, identification workflow, and verification approach validated on the 2D model of the first prototype extend to the second and final prototype: the full three-dimensional cube, where

three orthogonal reaction wheels must stabilise the body about its edge and corner equilibria.

### 3.4.1 Full-Body Equations of Motion

With  $R \in SO(3)$  the cube's orientation and  $\omega_b \in \mathbb{R}^3$  its body-frame angular velocity, the attitude kinematics are

$$\dot{R} = R[\omega_b]_{\times}, \quad (3)$$

where  $[\cdot]_{\times}$  is the skew-symmetric cross-product matrix. The assembly's angular momentum about the pivot, expressed in the body frame, generalizes the single-axis momentum term of the 2D model:

$$H = I\omega_b + \sum_{i=1}^3 I_{w,i} \omega_{w,i} e_i. \quad (4)$$

Euler's equation gives

$$\dot{H} + \omega_b \times H = \tau_g - C_b \omega_b, \quad (5)$$

and each wheel obeys

$$I_{w,i}(\dot{\omega}_{b,i} + \dot{\omega}_{w,i}) = T_{m,i} - C_{w,i} \omega_{w,i}, \quad i = 1, 2, 3. \quad (6)$$

Table 8 defines all symbols.

**Table 8:** Full-body (3D) model variables.

| Symbol                                                  | Description                                              |
|---------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| $R$                                                     | Cube orientation relative to world frame                 |
| $\omega_b$                                              | Body angular velocity, body frame ( $\in \mathbb{R}^3$ ) |
| $\omega_{b,i} = e_i^T \omega_b$                         | Body angular velocity about wheel axis $i$               |
| $\omega_w = (\omega_{w,1}, \omega_{w,2}, \omega_{w,3})$ | Wheel angular velocities relative to body                |
| $e_i$                                                   | Spin axis of wheel $i$ (face normal)                     |
| $I$                                                     | $3 \times 3$ inertia tensor, body+wheels, about pivot    |
| $H$                                                     | Total angular momentum about pivot                       |
| $\tau_g = m r_{cm} \times (R^T \hat{g})$                | Gravity torque about pivot                               |
| $m$                                                     | Total assembly mass                                      |
| $r_{cm}$                                                | Body-frame vector, pivot to assembly CoM                 |
| $\hat{g}$                                               | World vertical unit vector                               |
| $C_b$                                                   | $3 \times 3$ body damping matrix                         |
| $I_{w,i}, C_{w,i}$                                      | Inertia, damping of wheel $i$                            |
| $T_{m,i} = K_{m,i} u_i$                                 | Motor torque, wheel $i$                                  |
| $u_i, K_{m,i}$                                          | Motor current, torque constant, wheel $i$                |

Restricting motion to a single vertical plane with two wheel torques set to zero recovers the 2D model exactly, with  $I_b, l_b, m_b, m_w, I_w, C_b, C_w$  the corresponding single-axis projections of  $I, r_{cm}, m, I_{w,i}, C_{w,i}$ .

### 3.4.2 Edge vs. Corner Equilibria & Linearisation

Jump-up proceeds in two stages: Flat-to-Edge, where one wheel brakes, followed by Edge-to-Corner, where a second wheel brakes. **Edge balancing** constrains the body to a single axis, so the dynamics reduce to the 2D form of Section 3.2.1, with  $m_b, l_b, I_b$  replaced by their edge equivalents.

**Corner balancing** is genuinely 3D: all three wheels contribute across three rotational DOF. Linearising about the corner-up equilibrium  $(\theta, \omega_b, \omega_w) = (0, 0, 0)$ , with  $\theta \in \mathbb{R}^3$  the small orientation error, gives the same state-space form as the 2D case:

$$\dot{x}(t) = Ax(t) + Bu(t), \quad x := (\theta, \omega_b, \omega_w) \in \mathbb{R}^9, \quad (7)$$

with  $A \in \mathbb{R}^{9 \times 9}$  and  $B \in \mathbb{R}^{9 \times 3}$  built from  $I$ ,  $r_{cm}$ , and the per-wheel parameters  $I_{w,i}$ ,  $C_{w,i}$ ,  $K_{m,i}$  (Table 8). This linear model, together with its 2D counterpart of Section 3.2.1, is the plant the balancing controller of Section 7 is designed on.



## 4 Preliminary Sizing

This section establishes, before any part is committed to fabrication, that a cube built to a candidate mass and edge length can actually perform the jump-up manoeuvre and carry the components the design assumes. It states what sizing must satisfy (Section 1.3), the physics that turns a target manoeuvre into a required wheel inertia (Section 4.1), the packaging constraint that closes the loop between cube size and wheel size (Section 4.2) and the wheel design that meets the resulting target (Section 4.3).

Sizing and the control loop are not a sequence of independent steps: they are solved as one problem. The wheel inertia fixed here sets the angular momentum the controller has available to arrest a fall and the torque it has available to do so quickly, so a wheel sized without reference to the control law can be mechanically sufficient and dynamically useless. In the other direction, the control law’s own behaviour under saturation — how aggressively it must desaturate stored wheel momentum, and how much recovery angle it is asked to cover — determines how much margin the sizing needs to carry. Each of the two is therefore an input the other depends on, and the closure procedure of Section 4.2 is the fixed-point iteration that reconciles them, rather than a one-pass mechanical calculation handed to the controller afterwards.

### 4.1 Jump-Up Feasibility Analysis

Given CAD-derived  $I_b, I_w, m_b, l_b, m_w, l$ , the wheel speed  $\omega_w$  required for jump-up is estimated before fabrication, assuming a perfectly inelastic wheel-body collision. Conservation of angular momentum at impact and of energy from impact to edge-standing yield

$$\omega_w^2 = (2 - \sqrt{2}) \frac{I_w + I_b + m_w l^2}{I_w^2} (m_b l_b + m_w l) g. \quad (8)$$

This value is checked against the motor’s achievable speed at the available bus voltage and used to size wheel inertia (radius, rim mass) within the motor’s operating range without excessively reducing the balancing recovery angle. Post-fabrication,  $\omega_w$  is refined experimentally to correct for deviations from the ideal collision assumption.

The braking mechanism uses a servo-driven barrier that strikes a bolt head on the wheel to stop it abruptly. Servo response time bounds the validity of the “instantaneous stop” assumption; a slower stop yields a lower effective post-impact body velocity than predicted, compensated through the same tuning process.

#### 4.1.1 Torque-Limited Wheel-Inertia Target

The relation above assumes an instantaneous, lossless momentum transfer. For preliminary sizing, the achievable motor speed is treated as fixed and the required per-wheel inertia is derived from a momentum budget that additionally accounts for finite brake torque. This gives an ideal per-wheel angular momentum

$$h_{w,\text{ideal}} = \sqrt{\eta} \frac{\sqrt{2g\lambda\kappa}}{n} ML^{3/2}, \quad (9)$$

where  $M, L, g$  are cube mass, edge length, and gravity,  $\eta$  is an energy margin, and  $\kappa, \lambda, n$  are dimensionless geometric factors set by the contact case (Table 9). The corner case is more demanding and governs the design.

A finite brake torque  $\tau_b$  cannot deliver the impulse instantaneously and must exceed the gravitational tip-over torque  $\tau_g = MgL/2$ . This loss is captured by a brake-amplification factor

$$\beta = \frac{\tau_b}{\tau_b - \tau_g}, \quad h_w = \beta h_{w,\text{ideal}}, \quad I_{w,\text{target}} = \frac{h_w}{\omega_{\text{max}}}, \quad (10)$$

**Table 9:** Contact-case geometric factors.

| Case                    | $\kappa$ (pivot inertia) | $\lambda$ (CoM rise) | $n$ (momentum transfer) |
|-------------------------|--------------------------|----------------------|-------------------------|
| Edge                    | 2/3                      | $1/\sqrt{2} - 1/2$   | 1                       |
| Corner (governs design) | 11/12                    | $\sqrt{3}/2 - 1/2$   | $\sqrt{2}$              |

where  $\omega_{\max}$  is the maximum practical wheel speed. Equations (9) and (10) are the sizing relations used at step 4 of the closure procedure of Section 4.2: given a candidate cube mass and edge length they return the inertia the wheel of Section 4.3 must meet. Their inputs are recorded in Table 10 and are not fixed here— $M$  and  $L$  are outputs of the packaging closure, not assumptions preceding it.

Two features of these relations govern how the iteration behaves. First,  $h_w \propto ML^{3/2}$ , so growing the cube to accommodate a larger wheel also raises the requirement; convergence depends on the achievable inertia growing faster ( $\sim D_w^2$ ) than the requirement does. Second,  $\beta$  diverges as  $\tau_b \rightarrow \tau_g$ : a brake whose torque only marginally exceeds the gravitational tip-over torque cannot deliver the required impulse at any wheel speed. The brake torque must therefore be checked against  $\tau_g = MgL/2$  on every iteration, and a comfortable ratio  $\tau_b/\tau_g$  maintained rather than a merely positive margin.

**Table 10:** Torque-limited wheel-inertia target (corner case). Inputs are fixed by the closure procedure of Section 4.2; the table is populated on each iteration. Values are those of the converged iteration.

| Symbol                | Description                  | Value                                     |
|-----------------------|------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| $M$                   | Cube mass                    | 1.4654 kg                                 |
| $L$                   | Cube edge length             | 149 mm                                    |
| $\eta$                | Energy margin                | 1.05                                      |
| $\tau_b$              | Brake torque per wheel       | 5 N m (assumed; see below)                |
| $\tau_g = MgL/2$      | Gravitational tip-over floor | 1.071 N m                                 |
| $\beta$               | Brake-amplification factor   | 1.273                                     |
| $\omega_{\max}$       | Max wheel speed (design)     | 6000 rpm*                                 |
| $h_w$                 | Required angular momentum    | 0.1994 kg m <sup>2</sup> /s               |
| $I_{w,\text{target}}$ | <b>Target wheel inertia</b>  | $3.1735 \times 10^{-4}$ kg m <sup>2</sup> |

\* The sizing has additionally been run at 5000 rpm as an over-dimensioning check. Since  $I_{w,\text{target}} = h_w/\omega_{\max}$ , the lower speed raises the inertia requirement by a factor 6/5 and so demands more ballast; a wheel that closes at 5000 rpm therefore closes at 6000 rpm with margin in hand. 6000 rpm is the value the design claims, 5000 rpm the conservative case it was verified against.

**Selection of  $\omega_{\max}$ .** The maximum wheel speed is a design choice rather than a datasheet figure, and it enters the sizing directly through  $I_{w,\text{target}} = h_w/\omega_{\max}$ : a higher assumed speed permits a proportionally smaller wheel. It is therefore the primary relief variable when the envelope caps the wheel below the requirement (step 5, Table 11), but it must be set from what the drive can sustain in service, not from the no-load figure  $K_v V_{\text{bus}}$ . Three effects separate the two: winding resistance, which costs speed under the torque required to spin the wheel up; the reduced phase voltage available under sinusoidal field-oriented modulation; and the fall of pack voltage through the discharge curve, which must be taken at its lower end if the manoeuvre is to remain available on a partly-depleted pack rather than only on a fresh one. The design value is set below the ceiling those effects imply, leaving margin for motor tolerance, bearing and aerodynamic drag, and the residual uncertainty in  $M$ . The resulting back-EMF should remain a comfortable fraction of the usable bus voltage, and the electrical frequency  $\omega_{\max}p/2\pi$  at  $p$  pole pairs must sit inside

the driver's commutation capability—both checks to be confirmed once the motor and pack are selected.

**Selection of  $\tau_b$ .** The brake torque requires more care than the other inputs, because the mechanism does not generate it in the way the symbol suggests. The brake is a servo-driven barrier struck by a bolt head on the wheel: the servo only *holds* the barrier in the wheel's path, and the wheel's own momentum does the work of the collision. The servo's stall torque is therefore not  $\tau_b$  and need not approach it—the TowerPro MG92B of Table 22 is rated near 0.29 N m, roughly one seventeenth of the value used in sizing. The servo must resist the barrier being deflected, not decelerate the wheel.

Because the stop is a collision rather than a friction clutch,  $\tau_b$  is not an independent property of any component and cannot be read from a datasheet. It is fixed entirely by how quickly the angular momentum is destroyed,

$$\tau_b = \frac{h_w}{\Delta t}, \quad (11)$$

so quoting a brake torque is equivalent to asserting a stopping time. At the present operating point ( $h_w \approx 0.1994 \text{ kg m}^2/\text{s}$ ) the design value  $\tau_b = 5 \text{ N m}$  corresponds to  $\Delta t \approx 40 \text{ ms}$ . Stated that way the assumption is open to inspection: 40 ms is characteristic of servo travel rather than of a rigid impact, and a bolt head striking a printed barrier should arrest the wheel in a few milliseconds, implying a substantially larger  $\tau_b$ . The design value is thus expected to be conservative for *sizing* purposes.

That conservatism is deliberate, and it is asymmetric. Since  $\beta = \tau_b/(\tau_b - \tau_g)$  falls towards unity as  $\tau_b$  grows, underestimating the brake torque inflates the inertia requirement—the safe direction—while overestimating it leaves the wheel undersized. With the present  $\tau_g$ , raising  $\tau_b$  from 5–10 N m relaxes  $I_{w,\text{target}}$  by only about 12 %, whereas lowering it to 2 N m inflates the requirement by roughly 69 % and to 1.5 N m by roughly 175 %. The penalty for error is concentrated almost entirely on the low side, and a mid-range value is therefore adopted in preference to the higher figure a short impact would justify.

One consequence must be carried into the structural design rather than left implicit:  $\tau_b$  is also a *load*. The sizing value is chosen for the dynamics, and the same number should not be used to size the barrier, the bolt, the servo bracket or the wheel spokes, since a genuine few-millisecond stop would put an order of magnitude more torque through that load path. Until measurement settles the question, the structure is to be checked against a short- $\Delta t$  case and the dynamics against  $\tau_b = 5 \text{ N m}$ . The measurement that closes this is the spin-down test of Section ??, which should report both the impulse-equivalent mean  $\bar{\tau}_b = h_w/\Delta t$ , which is the sizing quantity, and the peak torque, which is the structural one; the two may differ several-fold, and the logging rate must be fast enough to resolve an event of a few milliseconds without smoothing the peak away.

## 4.2 Sizing Constraints and Closure Procedure

The cube edge length  $L$  and the reaction-wheel inertia  $I_w$  are not independent design choices: they are the two ends of a single constraint chain that begins with what must physically be carried inside the cube. This section states that chain and the order in which it is closed. No dimensions are committed here—component selection is still open (Sections 5 and 6), and the numbers follow from the procedure rather than preceding it.

The chain runs in the order set out in Table 11. The volume claim inside the cube is dominated by the LiPo pack and the inner structure that carries it — a rigid subframe locating the three motors on mutually perpendicular axes through a common centre, together with the drivers, flight controller, IMU and brake servos. The pack is incompressible and sits near the geometric centre so as not to skew the centre of mass off the body diagonal, so  $L$  is the smallest edge

length containing that volume plus wall thickness and the contact features.  $L$  then caps the wheel diameter  $D_w$ , and with it the achievable inertia  $I_w \sim m_w D_w^2/4$ ; ballast cannot rescue a wheel that is short at its maximum diameter, because it necessarily sits inboard of the ring it displaces.

Against that stands the requirement from the jump-up analysis (Section 4.1.1),

$$I_{w,\text{target}} = \frac{h_w(M, L)}{\omega_{\max}}, \quad h_w \propto ML^{3/2},$$

which rises with both  $M$  and  $L$ . Two consequences close the loop. Enlarging the cube to gain wheel diameter also raises the requirement, but the achievable inertia grows faster than the requirement does ( $D_w^2$  against  $L^{3/2}$ ), so a wheel short at a given  $L$  can be closed by a modest increase in  $L$ . And any mass added in doing so feeds back through  $h_w \propto M$  and through the gravitational tip-over torque  $\tau_g = MgL/2$  that the brake must exceed — which is why the procedure terminates at a fixed point rather than in one pass.

**Table 11:** Sizing closure procedure. Steps are executed in order; a failure at step 4 returns to step 3 or step 1 as indicated.

| Step | Determines                                                  | Governing consideration                                                                                       |
|------|-------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | Battery pack geometry                                       | Capacity and discharge rating for the jump-up duty cycle                                                      |
| 2    | Inner clear volume $V_{\min}$ , hence minimum $L$           | Pack + motor subframe + driver/controller stack, non-intersecting; pack near centre                           |
| 3    | Maximum wheel diameter $D_w$ , hence achievable $I_w$       | Clearance to subframe, motor body and the two orthogonal modules                                              |
| 4    | Requirement $I_{w,\text{target}} = h_w(M, L)/\omega_{\max}$ | Corner jump-up, Eqs. (9)–(10)                                                                                 |
| 5    | Accept or iterate                                           | If $I_w < I_{w,\text{target}}$ : raise $L$ (step 2), raise $\omega_{\max}$ , or trim $M$ ; re-enter at step 3 |
| 6    | Mass reconciliation                                         | Updated $M$ feeds back into step 4; iterate to a fixed point                                                  |

This procedure is implemented formally in `analysis/SIZING.py` and run to convergence by hand.

The two contact cases are not equally demanding. The corner equilibrium requires a larger rise of the centre of mass and a less favourable momentum-transfer geometry than the edge equilibrium, so for a common maximum wheel speed  $\omega_{\max}$  it demands the greater wheel inertia (Table 9). Step 4 above is therefore always evaluated for the corner case; a wheel that satisfies the corner requirement satisfies the edge requirement with margin. Table 12 records both once the procedure closes.

**Table 12:** Required per-wheel inertia by contact case, evaluated at  $\omega_{\max} = 6000$  rpm for the converged  $M = 1.4654$  kg. Only the geometry factor differs between the cases:  $\tau_g$  and  $\beta$  are properties of the cube and the brake, not of the feature it stands on.

| Contact case             | $h_w$ (kg m <sup>2</sup> /s) | $I_{w,\text{target}}$ (kg m <sup>2</sup> ) | Relative |
|--------------------------|------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|----------|
| Edge                     | 0.1809                       | $2.8790 \times 10^{-4}$                    | 90.7 %   |
| <b>Corner (critical)</b> | 0.1994                       | $3.1735 \times 10^{-4}$                    | 100 %    |

The corner case demands 9.3 % more inertia than the edge case, so sizing on it satisfies the

edge requirement with that margin in hand. The selected wheel delivers  $3.6903 \times 10^{-4} \text{ kg m}^2$  (Table 14), which is 116.3% of the corner requirement and 128.2% of the edge requirement.

The allocation of Table 13 is the bookkeeping side of steps 5 and 6: it is populated as components are selected and re-totalled on each iteration, since the total is an input to  $I_{w,\text{target}}$  as well as an output of the design.

**Table 13:** Mass budget (per cube), rolled up from the bill of materials by `analysis/SIZING.py` (Stage 6). The total is an input to the inertia requirement, not only a result: the value below is the *converged* one, which the closure reproduces exactly ( $\delta = 0.0 \text{ g}$ ) against the  $M$  assumed in Table 10.

| Subsystem                                       | Mass (g)      | Share                        | Basis                         |
|-------------------------------------------------|---------------|------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| Reaction wheels ( $3 \times 149.11 \text{ g}$ ) | 447.3         | 30.5 %                       | Sized (Sec. 4.3)              |
| Motors and brake servos ( $3 \times$ each)      | 245.4         | 16.7 %                       | Datasheet                     |
| Power (battery, XT60, regulator)                | 279.0         | 19.0 %                       | Drives envelope (step 1)      |
| Electronics (drivers, MCU, encoders, IMU)       | 74.2          | 5.1 %                        | Datasheet                     |
| Wiring, perfboard and passives                  | 45.5          | 3.1 %                        | Estimated                     |
| <b>Subtotal — specified hardware</b>            | <b>1091.4</b> | <b>74.5 %</b>                | Measured or datasheet         |
| Structure (subframe, frame, fasteners)          | 374.0         | 25.5 %                       | <b>Allowance, pending CAD</b> |
| <b>Total <math>M</math></b>                     | <b>1465.4</b> | <b>Converged fixed point</b> |                               |

The structure line is an *allowance*, not a measurement, and at roughly 26% of the total it is still the dominant uncertainty in the budget, even after the 610 g figure of the previous iteration was revised down to 374 g (sub-frame 153 g, frame 184 g, fasteners/harness 37 g, held at the same relative split). It is reported separately from the specified hardware for that reason: the subtotal is what the design currently knows, and the total is what it currently projects. Closing the CAD model replaces the allowance with a real figure and re-enters the loop at step 6.

### 4.3 Reaction-Wheel Sizing

The wheel must supply the per-wheel inertia  $I_{w,\text{target}}$  demanded by the corner jump-up (Section 4.1.1), at an outer diameter no greater than the envelope permits (step 3 of Table 11), while remaining light enough not to dominate the cube mass—since its own mass feeds back into  $I_{w,\text{target}}$  through  $M$ . These three demands pull against each other, and the wheel architecture is chosen so that the design can be trimmed against them after fabrication rather than having to be right the first time.

**Architecture: ballasted ring.** Rather than adjusting inertia by scaling a solid disc, the wheel is built as a printed *ring plus spokes* whose inertia is then tuned by *ballast*: standard M6 steel bolt-and-nut sets fitted through round clearance holes drilled *radially* through the ring’s cross-section, from the inner bore surface to the outer rim surface — a true ID-to-OD through-hole, not one drilled through the wheel’s face. Each hole’s depth is therefore fixed at the ring’s radial width, and its centroid sits at the ring’s mean radius  $R_{\text{mean}} = (D_w + D_i)/4$  by construction: unlike a face-drilled hole there is no free pitch-circle radius to choose. The hole diameter is instead capped by the wheel’s axial thickness, with a printed wall retained on both faces. Each station both removes plastic and adds steel at very nearly the largest available radius, so the net inertia gain per station is large, and the target is reached by choosing how many of the available stations to populate.

The bolt passing through the ring is also the retention feature: the nut threads onto it and clamps the ring, so nothing depends on a plastic pocket floor. Each station carries the centrifugal load  $F = m_{\text{hw}} \omega_{\text{max}}^2 R_{\text{mean}}$  of its own hardware, reacted by the bolt in tension and by bearing of the head and nut faces — now against the ring’s curved ID and OD surfaces rather than a flat

face, so both are spot-faced flat (or fitted with a curved washer) to seat squarely — checked in Section ??, and a nyloc or threadlocked nut is specified so that vibration cannot back it off.

The geometry is defined by the quantities of Table 14, all of which follow from the envelope closure of Section 4.2 and are recorded there once fixed.

**Table 14:** Reaction-wheel geometry and ballast parameters. Values are the current design point of the iteration described below; they are provisional while the structural mass of Table 13 remains an allowance.

| Symbol            | Parameter                                                                | Value                                                |
|-------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| $D_w$             | Ring outer diameter (fixed by envelope)                                  | 120 mm                                               |
| $D_i$             | Ring inner diameter ( $D_w - 2w_r$ )                                     | 100 mm                                               |
| $w_r$             | Ring radial width (= ballast hole depth)                                 | 10 mm                                                |
| $t$               | Wheel axial thickness (caps hole diameter)                               | 20 mm                                                |
| $n_s, w_s$        | Spoke count and width                                                    | 3, 10 mm                                             |
| $\rho_p$          | Printed-material density (PET-CF)                                        | 1290 kg/m <sup>3</sup>                               |
| $d_h$             | Ballast hole diameter (M6 clearance)                                     | 6.4 mm                                               |
| $R_{\text{mean}}$ | Ballast centroid radius (forced, = $(D_w + D_i)/4$ )                     | 55.0 mm                                              |
| $m_{\text{hw}}$   | Hardware mass per station (bolt + nut)                                   | 7.5 g                                                |
| $m_b$             | <i>Net</i> mass added per station                                        | 7.085 g                                              |
| $\Delta I_b$      | <i>Net</i> inertia added per station                                     | $2.151 \times 10^{-5}$ kg m <sup>2</sup>             |
| $N$               | Station count reaching $I_{w,\text{target}}$ (of $N_{\text{max}} = 37$ ) | 3                                                    |
| $m_w$             | Resulting wheel mass                                                     | 149.11 g                                             |
| $I_w$             | Resulting wheel inertia<br>as a fraction of $I_{w,\text{target}}$        | $3.6903 \times 10^{-4}$ kg m <sup>2</sup><br>116.3 % |

The ballast is characterised *net* of the plastic each hole displaces:  $m_b$  and  $\Delta I_b$  are the increments the installed bolt-and-nut adds over the radial cylinder of material it replaces, evaluated at the forced centroid radius  $R_{\text{mean}}$ . Both corrections are taken about the spin axis by the parallel-axis theorem, retaining each feature’s own-axis term rather than treating it as a point mass — here the *transverse* solid-cylinder term  $r_h^2/4 + w_r^2/12$ , since the hole’s own axis is radial and therefore perpendicular to the spin axis, not parallel to it as a face-drilled hole’s would be. Sizing then reduces to solving

$$I_w(D_w, N) = I_{w,\text{ring}}(D_w) + N \Delta I_b \geq I_{w,\text{target}}$$

for the smallest admissible  $N$  at each candidate  $D_w$ , subject to the fit and mass checks below.

**Sizing calculator and iteration procedure.** The relations above are implemented as a parametric calculator that maps the geometry of Table 14 onto the mass and inertia of one wheel, sweeping candidate outer diameters and returning, for each, the station count required, the count the gap rule admits, the resulting mass and inertia, and the pass/fail state of every constraint. It is not an optimiser, and the design point it reports was not found by one.

The outer diameter is not among the quantities it is free to choose.  $D_w$  is *imposed* by the packaging envelope—three orthogonal wheel modules and the battery must fit within  $L$ —so the sweep is retained for what it reveals rather than for what it selects. Left free to minimise wheel mass it prefers a somewhat larger ring, since  $I_{zz}$  scales as  $mR^2$  and mass placed at a large radius buys inertia more cheaply; the free optimum at the present target is 130 mm (139.83 g/wheel, no ballast needed), so at 120 mm the envelope constraint costs about 9.3 g per wheel (27.8 g over three) against that unconstrained optimum — a modest penalty at the present, lighter design point. This is the price of a wheel that fits, and a wheel that does not fit is not a candidate.

The procedure actually followed is the fixed-point iteration of Table 11, executed by hand. A cube mass is estimated and a mass budget assembled from it; the jump-up analysis converts that mass into an inertia requirement; the wheel is sized against the requirement subject to the internal-volume and hole-pattern constraints; and the resulting wheel mass is returned to the budget, which changes the mass that started the loop. The cycle repeats until it lands on a geometry that simultaneously fits the internal volume, admits a station count satisfying the inertia requirement, and reproduces the cube mass it assumed. Convergence is what closes the design: the reported point is one at which the assumed and the totalled mass agree, so step 6 of Table 11 returns approximately zero.

Selection among admissible diameters is made on minimum *wheel mass* rather than minimum diameter.

## 5 CAD Design

This design is preliminary: final actuator and sensor specifications are not yet confirmed, so the mechanical architecture is kept modular and largely parametric (Section 1.1). This section states the mechanical concept and the CAD conventions the build follows, for both the first prototype (the single-face 1-DoF rig) and the second and final prototype (the three-axis cube), and the checks that confirm the model and the fabricated parts agree. It is deliberately kept to the level of decisions and interfaces: the part-by-part model tree, the manufacturing drawings, the fabrication settings and the assembly sequence are recorded in Appendix B, so that a change to a bracket does not require an edit to the design rationale, and the rationale is not buried in geometry.

### 5.1 Mechanical Design and CAD Construction

#### 5.1.1 CAD Methodology and Model Conventions

The model is built top-down from the envelope closure of Section 4.2 rather than bottom-up from individual parts, so that the edge length  $L$  and the wheel diameter  $D_w$  propagate to every dependent feature when an iteration changes them. Three conventions make that propagation reliable, and they are stated here because they constrain how every part in Appendix B is modelled:

1. **A single skeleton drives the assembly.**  $L$ ,  $D_w$ , the motor axis offsets and the wall thickness live in one parameter table referenced by every part; no downstream part carries a hard-coded dimension that duplicates one of them.
2. **The body frame is the CAD origin.** The assembly origin is the cube's geometric centre, with axes on the three motor spin axes, so that CAD-reported mass properties are directly the  $I$  and  $r_{cm}$  of Table 8 without a change of basis.
3. **Mass properties are an output of the model, not an annotation.** Every part carries its assigned material and print density, so the assembly mass roll-up is the quantity fed back into Table 13 at step 6 of Table 11.

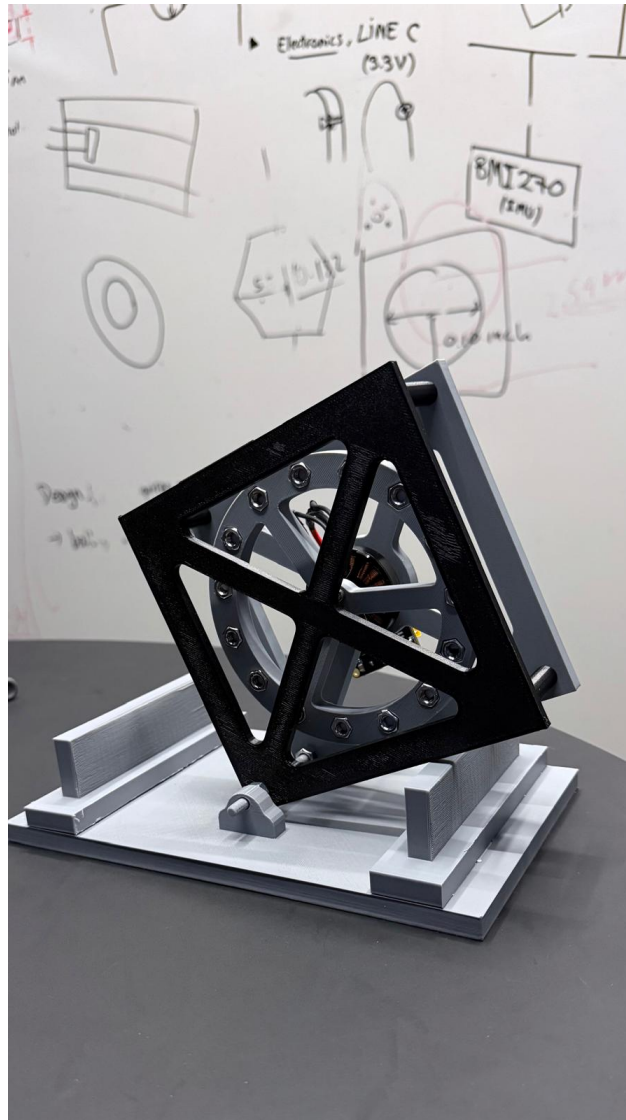
Convention 3 makes the iteration auditable: the mass budget and the inertia requirement are read from the same model, so a design that closes analytically cannot fail to close in the CAD without the discrepancy being detected.

#### 5.1.2 1-DoF Prototype Build

The single-face rig is the first article built and the bench on which the parameters of Table 6 are measured. Its structure is a 3D-printed plate sized to one cube face, a central motor and wheel mount, a corner bearing defining the single rotational degree of freedom, and encoders and other hardware. Note that the servo (brake system) is not included in the 1-DoF prototype as its purpose is validating the control loop on a more well-understood problem. Detailed geometry and the drawing set are in Appendix B.3.

The rig as built is shown in Figure 6. The plate is mounted diagonally, so that the pivot bearing sits at the lowest corner and the wheel axis passes through the plate centre: this places the centre of mass directly above the contact point at the upright equilibrium, which is the configuration linearised in Section 7. The two printed uprights either side of the frame are hard stops, limiting travel to a few degrees past the point of no return so that a failed balancing attempt ends against a stop rather than on the bench.





**Figure 6:** The single-face prototype rig as built: one reaction wheel driven by a brushless motor on a diagonally-mounted printed plate, pivoting on a corner bearing against a printed base with hard stops. This is the article on which the plant parameters of Table 6 are measured and the single-axis controller of Section 7 is validated before the three-axis build. The drawing set is given in Appendix B.3.

### 5.1.3 3D Cube Frame

The frame is conceived in two parts, reflecting the constraint chain of Section 4.2. An *inner structure* locates the three motors on mutually perpendicular axes through a common centre and carries the battery pack, the three drivers, the flight controller, inertial measurement unit, and the brake servos; it is the element that fixes the minimum internal clear volume and therefore the edge length  $L$ . An *outer frame* carries the edge and corner contact features, protects the wheels, and reacts the motor mounting loads from the inner structure into the ground contact.

A first physical prototype of this frame has been printed and is shown in Figure 7. It is explicitly a *concept prototype*, not the flight article: it demonstrates the two-part architecture, the X-braced face pattern and the packaging of three orthogonal wheel modules within the cube envelope, and it serves as a physical check on clearances that are awkward to judge on screen. The final design is not frozen. Detailed geometry follows the envelope closure of Section 4.2, and the wheel dimensions in particular remain open pending the sizing iteration of Section 4.3 and confirmation of the final motor; the mass properties of the printed prototype are therefore not the mass properties assumed in the budget.

The split is also the main mechanical interface in the machine, and it is managed as one: the inner structure is designed against a fixed bolt pattern and keep-out envelope published to the outer frame, so the two can be revised independently as long as that interface holds. The controlled interfaces are listed in Table 15; the parts realising them, with their drawings, are in Appendix B.4.

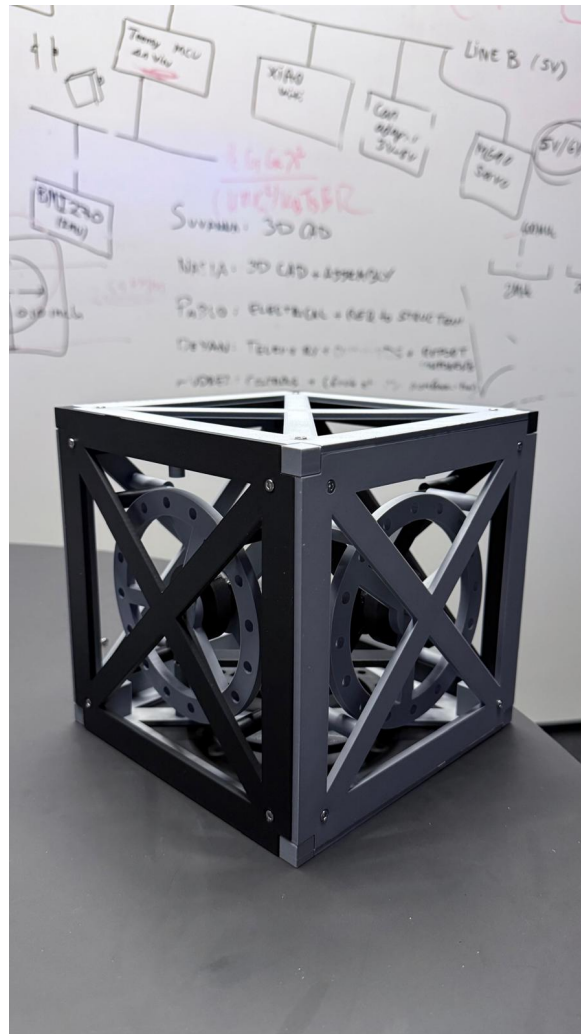
**Table 15:** Controlled mechanical interfaces. Each is frozen once agreed, so that the parts on either side can be revised independently.

| Interface         | Between                                       | Controlled quantities                                                                        |
|-------------------|-----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Motor mount       | Motor $\leftrightarrow$ inner structure       | Bolt circle, shaft height, concentricity to the wheel axis                                   |
| Wheel hub         | Wheel $\leftrightarrow$ motor rotor           | Bore, bolt pattern, axial location, balance datum                                            |
| Frame joint       | Inner structure $\leftrightarrow$ outer frame | Bolt pattern, keep-out envelope, load path to the contact features                           |
| Electronics mount | Board $\leftrightarrow$ inner structure       | Board outline, mounting-hole pattern, keep-out heights, connector exit directions (Sec. 6.6) |
| Brake mount       | Servo $\leftrightarrow$ inner structure       | Servo location, barrier throw                                                                |
| Battery retention | Pack $\leftrightarrow$ inner structure        | Pack envelope, retention method, centring tolerance to the cube centre                       |
| Contact features  | Outer frame $\leftrightarrow$ ground          | Corner and edge geometry, material, replaceability                                           |

## 5.2 CAD and Dimensional Verification

The checks below split into those that run against the model, before anything is fabricated, and those that run against the physical part afterwards. The driving dimensions themselves are outputs of the packaging closure of Section 4.2 and are not verified here; what is verified is that the model realises them consistently and that the fabricated part matches the model.

**Model checks (pre-fabrication).** Interference and clearance verification on the wheel-to-subframe and inter-module clearances  $c_w$  and  $c_o$  of Table 23, through a full rotation of each wheel and across all three axes simultaneously; orthogonality of the three motor axes; position



**Figure 7:** Printed concept prototype of the three-axis cube frame, showing the X-braced outer faces and the three orthogonal reaction-wheel modules carried by the inner structure. This article validates the two-part architecture and the internal packaging only: it is *not* the final design. Wheel geometry and the frame edge length  $L$  remain subject to the sizing closure of Sections 4.2 and 4.3, so its mass properties do not represent the budgeted values. Drawings of the frozen design will be issued in Appendix B.4.

of the centre of mass relative to the geometric centre, since the modelling of Section 3 assumes a known offset; and the mass roll-up against Table 13, which is the input to the sizing verification of Section ?? and must be re-run whenever it changes.

**Part checks (post-fabrication).** Dimensional acceptance of the ballast holes — diameter, pitch circle radius and the radial wall left on each side — since these are structural features rather than cosmetic ones and a print that is dimensionally out of tolerance at a hole is a wheel that cannot be trusted at speed; verification that each bolt is torqued and its nyloc nut engaged, the through-bolt being the retention feature; measured wheel mass against the CAD prediction; and static balance of the assembled wheel, which is the first opportunity to detect a ballast placement error before it appears as vibration at speed.

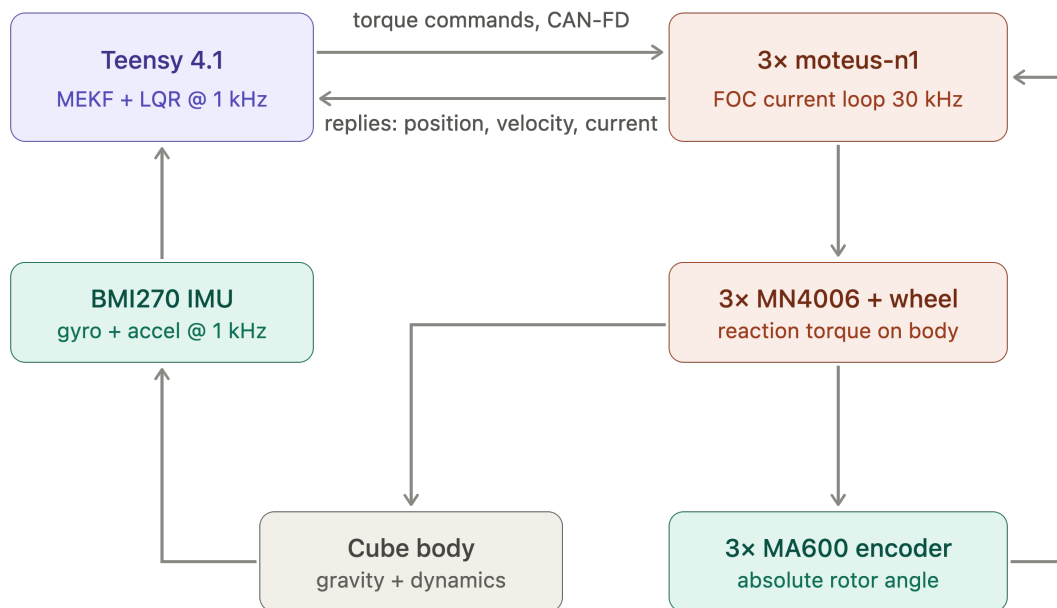
The modelled-versus-measured comparison is recorded in Table 27 of Appendix B.6 and is not duplicated here. A discrepancy found at that step is carried back into  $I_{w,\text{target}}$  and absorbed by ballast trim where the authority allows, per Section ??; where it does not, the finding returns to the closure procedure rather than being accepted.

## 6 Electronics

This section is presented at the level of the decisions that shape the electrical architecture: what the components are, how the whole system loop fits together, how power is distributed, how the buses are routed and terminated, and how the assembly is made safe to power on. The sheet-level schematics, the connector and pin tables, the harness drawings and the perfboard layout are collected in Appendix C, for the same reason the CAD detail is separated from the mechanical rationale of Section 5 — a connector re-pin should not require an edit here. The acceptance criteria and checks run against this architecture during bring-up (CAN-bus termination, rail voltages, sensor and driver calibration) are tracked against the electrical bring-up stage of the validation strategy (Section ??), not repeated here.

### 6.1 System Architecture

Figure 8 shows the closed control loop that ties the four subsystems together. The Teensy 4.1 runs estimation and control at 1 kHz and issues torque commands over CAN-FD to three moteus-n1 drivers, each closing a 30 kHz field-oriented current loop on its MN4006 motor. The resulting reaction torque acts on the cube body; the body’s attitude is sensed by the BMI270 IMU and the rotor angle by the MA600 absolute encoder, closing the loop back to the controller. The two loops run at different rates by design: the fast current loop is delegated entirely to the drivers, so the flight controller need only meet the 1 ms outer-loop deadline of Section 7.



**Figure 8:** System architecture and control loop. Blue: processing; green: sensing; orange: actuation. Rates shown are the design targets of Section 7.

### 6.2 Components

The electronics and software are built around the Teensy 4.1 microcontroller, which communicates over the CAN-FD bus with the mjbots moteus-n1 driver that closes the current loop for the MN4006 brushless motor. Wheel speed is measured with the MA600 magnetic encoder on the motor shaft, and body tilt is estimated from the BMI270 IMU. Braking is actuated by a

TowerPro MG92B digital servo driven directly from the microcontroller, and the XIAO ESP32-C6 wireless module provides a telemetry and debugging link. Power is supplied by the 6S LiPo battery, stepped down through an LM2596 DC-DC converter for the logic-level electronics, with the motor drivers powered directly from the battery bus.

The full parts list is catalogued in Appendix A (Table 22). The supplied set is an electronics-only BOM; the reaction wheels, the frame and all printed parts are the team's design responsibility, and their fabrication is the leading schedule risk.

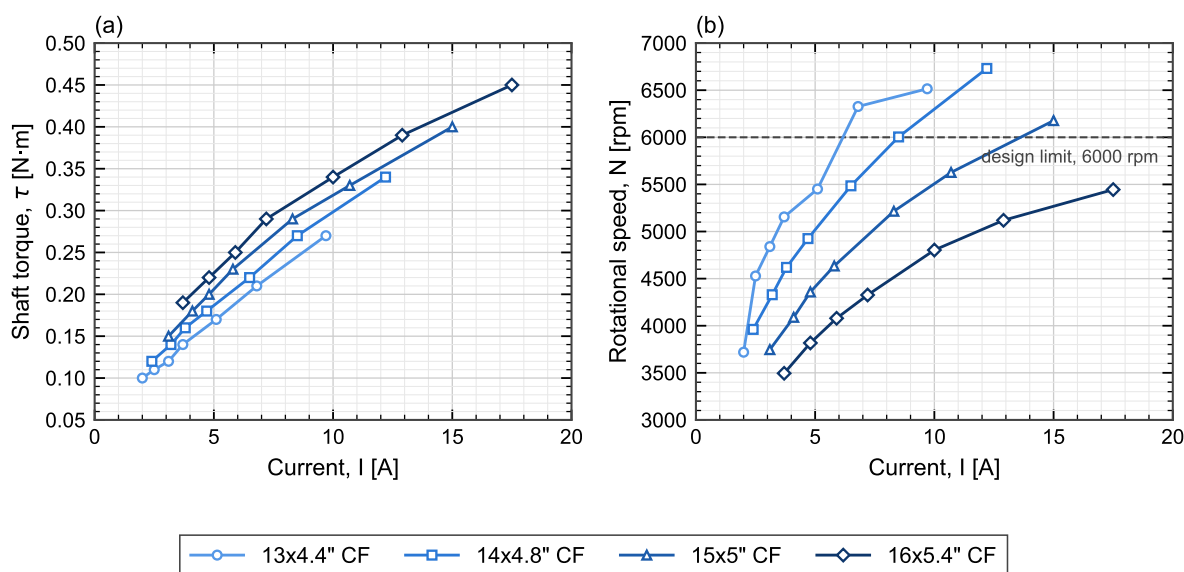
**Motor characterisation and operating envelope.** Figure 9 shows measured torque and speed against phase current for the MN4006, taken from manufacturer bench data. The measurements were made with the motor driving propellers rather than reaction wheels, so the *load* is not representative of this application — an aerodynamic load rises with the square of speed, whereas a reaction wheel is an inertia with only bearing friction opposing it at constant speed. What does transfer is the motor's own electromechanical behaviour, since torque per ampere and back-EMF per unit speed are properties of the machine and not of what it is attached to. The curves are used here only in that sense: to bound the torque and current the actuator can be expected to deliver.

Three figures relevant to the design follow from the data. First, the torque–current relation in Figure 9(a) is close to linear ( $r = 0.97$ ) with an incremental slope of  $0.023 \text{ N m/A}$  and a positive torque-axis intercept of about  $0.08 \text{ N m}$ . The intercept is the expected signature of losses that do not reach the shaft — magnetising and iron losses plus bearing friction — so the useful torque per ampere is the slope, and a constant inferred by simply dividing torque by current at a single point would overstate it (that ratio runs to  $0.031 \text{ N m/A}$  through the origin). Either way the motor produces at most  $0.45 \text{ N m}$ , an order of magnitude below the  $5 \text{ N m}$  brake torque assumed in Section 4.1.1. The two are not alternatives: the motor stores angular momentum in the wheel over about a second, and the brake destroys it in tens of milliseconds, so the impulsive torque comes from the collision and not from the drive. This is why braking is a separate mechanism rather than a motor function. Second, the highest measured point reaches  $0.45 \text{ N m}$  at  $17.5 \text{ A}$ , above the  $16 \text{ A}$  peak rating in Table 22, and that run terminated on the motor's thermal limit — so the top of this envelope is a short-duration capability, not a continuous one. Third, speeds cross the  $6000 \text{ rpm}$  design ceiling of Section 4.2 only under the lighter loads, which is consistent with that ceiling being set by bus voltage and derating rather than by any inability of the motor to spin faster.

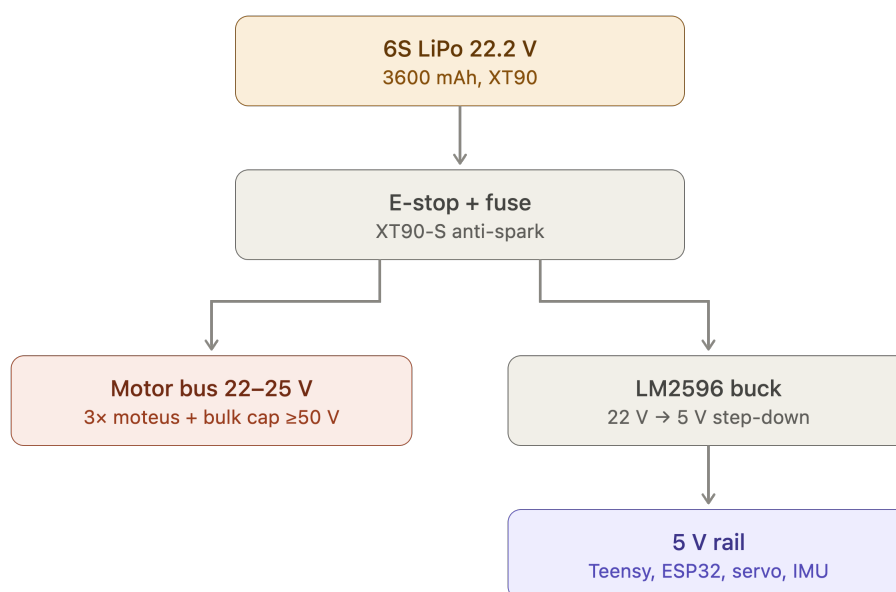
### 6.3 Power Architecture

The power architecture is shown in Figure 10. A single 6S LiPo pack ( $22.2 \text{ V}$  nominal,  $1550 \text{ mA h}$ ) feeds everything through one XT60 connector, behind a combined E-stop and fuse, with an anti-spark path to limit inrush into the driver bulk capacitance. The XT60 is fixed by the pack rather than chosen: it is rated at  $\approx 60 \text{ A}$ , which covers the three-axis spin-up transient but with a smaller margin than a  $90 \text{ A}$  housing would give, so the transient is a measured acceptance item at first power-on rather than an assumed one. The bus then splits into two rails. The *motor bus* runs at pack voltage ( $22\text{--}25 \text{ V}$  across the discharge curve) directly into the three motor drivers, with bulk capacitance rated to at least  $50 \text{ V}$  to absorb regenerative braking transients—which are not incidental here, since the jump-up manoeuvre of Section 4.1 dumps the full wheel kinetic energy back into the bus. The *logic rail* is derived by an LM2596 buck converter stepping  $22 \text{ V}$  down to  $5 \text{ V}$  for the Teensy, the ESP32 telemetry link, the three brake servos and the IMU. Keeping the two rails separate downstream of the E-stop means motor-current ripple does not reach the sensing and processing electronics.

The rail-by-rail current budget that sizes the buck converter and the harness conductors is



**Figure 9:** Measured MN4006 (a) shaft torque and (b) rotational speed against phase current, for one motor driving four different loads. Symbols are measured points at throttle settings of 50, 55, 60, 65, 75, 85 and 100 %; lines join successive points and are not fits. The dashed line in (b) is the 6000rpm reaction-wheel design ceiling of Section 4.2. Loads shown are propellers, not reaction wheels: the curves characterise the *motor*, and the load-dependent spread between them does not carry over to this application. Manufacturer static bench data; the heaviest load reached the motor thermal limit at 100 % throttle.



**Figure 10:** Power distribution tree. A single 6S pack feeds the motor bus directly and the 5 V logic rail through a buck converter, both behind a common E-stop and fuse.

Table 16. It is populated from measurement during bench bring-up rather than from datasheet maxima alone, because the figure that matters for the 5 V rail is the coincident worst case — telemetry transmit burst, servo stall and full sensor load at once — and not the sum of typical values.

**Table 16:** Rail current budget. Measured values replace estimates during bench bring-up; the 5 V total is checked against the LM2596 rating, which derates without a heatsink.

| Load                    | Rail | Typical (mA) | Worst case (mA) | Basis                              |
|-------------------------|------|--------------|-----------------|------------------------------------|
| Teensy 4.1              | 5 V  | TBD          | TBD             | Datasheet                          |
| XIAO ESP32-C6 telemetry | 5 V  | TBD          | TBD             | TX burst governs                   |
| BMI270 IMU              | 5 V  | TBD          | TBD             | Datasheet                          |
| MG92B brake servos (3×) | 5 V  | TBD          | TBD             | Simultaneous stall current governs |
| MA600 encoders (3×)     | 5 V  | TBD          | TBD             | Datasheet                          |
| <b>Logic rail total</b> | 5 V  | <b>TBD</b>   | <b>TBD</b>      | <b>vs. converter rating</b>        |
| moteus-n1 drivers (3×)  | Pack | TBD          | TBD             | Spin-up, not balance, governs      |

## 6.4 Schematic and Interconnect Diagrams

The signal-level design is captured as one flat schematic (Figure 20, Appendix C.1), together with the connector and pin-assignment tables. Table 17 states, block by block, the constraint each part of that capture is checked against before bring-up.

**Table 17:** Electrical design constraints by block. Each is checked against the capture of Figure 20 before bring-up.

| Block                      | Governing constraint to verify                                                                  |
|----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Power entry and protection | E-stop, fuse rating, anti-spark inrush into the driver bulk capacitance                         |
| 5 V logic rail             | Converter rating vs. Table 16 worst case; back-feed diode; rail bulk capacitance voltage rating |
| CAN-FD bus                 | Linear topology, stub length, split termination at the two physical ends only (Sec. 6.5)        |
| Encoder interfaces (3×)    | SPI cable length and encoder air gap; driver placement follows from this, not the reverse       |
| Flight computer and IMU    | Sensor orientation and mounting location relative to the pivot (Sec. 7)                         |
| Telemetry link             | Transmit-burst current and its return path off the logic rail                                   |
| Brake servo drive          | Stall current headroom on the logic rail; PWM routing away from the encoder SPI                 |

## 6.5 Bus Topology, Termination and Signal Integrity

The CAN-FD bus is the one electrical subsystem whose physical routing is a correctness requirement, and it is therefore fixed before the board outline is drawn. At the design data rate the bus must be a linear chain with short stubs and termination at exactly the two physical ends; a star topology or a mid-chain termination will pass a bench continuity check and then



fail intermittently under wheel vibration, which is the hardest class of fault to diagnose once the cube is closed. The design rules and their verification are listed in Table 18.

The encoder interfaces impose the complementary constraint. Each absolute encoder requires a short SPI run to its own driver and a tightly held air gap to its magnet, so the driver positions are dictated by the encoder positions, and those in turn by the motor axes. The physical layout order is therefore: motor axes fix the encoders, encoders fix the drivers, drivers fix the bus route, and only then is the board outline of Section 6.6 drawn around what remains.

**Table 18:** Signal-integrity design rules and how each is verified. These are checked before cube closure, since all are hard to access afterwards.

| Interface       | Rule                                                                         | Verification                                                                                       |
|-----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| CAN-FD bus      | Linear chain; short stubs; split termination at the two physical ends only   | Differential-pair scope capture; sustained error-frame count at full rate with all nodes addressed |
| Encoder SPI     | Short run to its own driver; air gap and chip centring per the assembly spec | Read-back with no error flags; re-checked after mechanical assembly                                |
| IMU             | Mounted at or near the pivot; orientation per the body frame of Sec. 5.1.1   | Static orientation check; noise floor with wheels spinning                                         |
| Rail separation | Motor bus and logic rail separated downstream of the E-stop                  | Ripple measurement on the logic rail under motor load                                              |
| Grounding       | Single return topology; no motor return current through the sensing ground   | Continuity and isolation check before first power-on                                               |

## 6.6 Board Layout and Harness

The electronics are built on a double-sided perfboard rather than a fabricated PCB. A PCB would have a long lead time, and a perfboard allows for iteration and modification throughout the process. Its consequence is that layout discipline — rail separation, decoupling at each device, deliberate routing of the bus pair — must be enforced by hand and checked explicitly, since no design-rule check will do it.

The board outline, mounting-hole pattern, keep-out heights and connector exit directions constitute the electronics-mount interface of Table 15 and are frozen once delivered to the mechanical design: later electrical changes must fit inside that outline rather than move it. The harness — battery lead, driver drops, bus chain and servo drive — is fabricated to the drawings in Appendix C.3 and is labelled and strain-relieved before installation, because every connector in the machine sits on a structure that vibrates by design.

## 6.7 Electrical Safety and Bring-Up Protocol

Two rules govern all electrical bring-up and are stated here because they are design constraints, not merely lab practice. First, every first-time power application is made on a current-limited bench supply, never on the battery; the battery is introduced only after the assembly has passed a full bench power-on. Second, the pack is never connected without the E-stop and fuse in circuit and the anti-spark path intact, since the driver bulk capacitance draws an inrush that will weld a bare connector.

The staged sequence — rails, then buses, then sensors, then open-loop motion, then closed-loop — and the acceptance criteria that close each step are tracked against the validation stage gates

of Section ?? . The isolation checks that precede first power-on (rail-to-rail separation, bus-to-chassis, and confirmation that no low-voltage capacitor sits on the pack bus) are recorded in Appendix C as a checklist, because they are performed on every re-assembly and not only once.

## 7 Control Algorithms & Approach

This section derives the balancing controller from the linear models of Section 3, states the controller as executable logic rather than only as equations, describes the Simulink/Simscape environment used to exercise that logic against both prototypes' CAD geometry before it runs on hardware, and gives the onboard software architecture that carries it at 1 kHz in flight. Detailed pseudocode, the fixed gains and tuning parameters, the timing budget and the fault responses are collected in Appendix D.

### 7.1 LQR Baseline Control

Linearising about the upright equilibrium  $(\theta_b, \dot{\theta}_b, \dot{\theta}_w) = (0, 0, 0)$  gives

$$\dot{x}(t) = Ax(t) + Bu(t), \quad x := (\theta_b, \dot{\theta}_b, \dot{\theta}_w), \quad (12)$$

with  $A, B$  built from the parameters in Table 5. Zero-order-hold discretization at a rate set by the open-loop unstable pole, with a safety margin, gives  $x[k+1] = A_d x[k] + B_d u[k]$ . A discrete LQR gain  $K_d = (K_{d1}, K_{d2}, K_{d3})$  minimises

$$J(u) = \sum_k x^T[k] Q x[k] + u^T[k] R u[k], \quad (13)$$

giving  $u[k] = -K_d(\hat{\theta}_b[k], \hat{\dot{\theta}}_b[k], \hat{\dot{\theta}}_w[k])$ . The same design generalises directly to the corner-balancing 9-state model of Section 3.4:  $K_d$  becomes a  $3 \times 9$  gain matrix, using the same discretization, cost function and offset filter below, with  $Q, R$  weighting all three tilt axes, body rates and wheel speeds.

The tilt estimate  $\hat{\theta}_b$  is obtained from a gyroscope and accelerometer mounted at, or as close as mechanically feasible to, the pivot point rather than at the plate's centre. This placement is necessary because an accelerometer at radius  $r$  from the pivot measures gravity plus the tangential ( $r\ddot{\theta}_b$ ) and centripetal ( $r\dot{\theta}_b^2$ ) acceleration components induced by the plate's rotation, which corrupt the naive estimate  $\tan^{-1}(-a_x/a_y)$  during fast motion (e.g., jump-up or aggressive recovery); placing the sensor at  $r \approx 0$  makes both terms negligible. Tilt is estimated with a complementary filter combining gyro integration (drift-prone, unaffected by the terms above) with accelerometer inclination (drift-free, but unreliable during shocks):

$$\hat{\theta}_b[k] = (1 - \gamma)(\hat{\theta}_b[k-1] + \dot{\theta}_{b,\text{gyro}}[k] \Delta t) + \gamma \theta_{b,\text{accel}}[k], \quad (14)$$

where  $\theta_{b,\text{accel}}[k] = \tan^{-1}(-a_x[k]/a_y[k])$  is the instantaneous accelerometer-only estimate and  $\gamma \in (0, 1)$  is a small weight favoring the gyro term between corrections.

A constant tilt-sensor offset  $d$ , including residual bias from imperfect pivot placement or sensor misalignment, would otherwise appear as a nonzero steady-state wheel speed rather than a corrected angle. A low-pass filter state

$$x_f[k+1] = (1 - \alpha)x_f[k] + \alpha\hat{\theta}_b[k] \quad (15)$$

is subtracted from the tilt feedback,

$$u[k] = -K_d(\hat{\theta}_b[k] - x_f[k], \hat{\dot{\theta}}_b[k], \hat{\dot{\theta}}_w[k]), \quad (16)$$

so  $d$  is absorbed by  $x_f$  at steady state, requiring no separate calibration stage. This fixed-gain design is the baseline balancing controller; Table 19 summarizes the control variables.

**Table 19:** Control-design variables (2D and corner-balancing 3D model).

| Symbol                                 | Description                                             |
|----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| $x$                                    | State vector                                            |
| $A, B$                                 | Continuous-time state/input matrices (linearised model) |
| $A_d, B_d$                             | Discrete-time (ZOH) counterparts of $A, B$              |
| $K_d$                                  | LQR feedback gain                                       |
| $Q, R$                                 | LQR state/input weighting matrices                      |
| $J(u)$                                 | LQR cost function                                       |
| $\hat{\theta}_b, \dot{\hat{\theta}}_b$ | Estimated tilt angle, rate (gyroscope/accelerometer)    |
| $\dot{\hat{\theta}}_w$                 | Estimated wheel rate (encoder)                          |
| $a_x, a_y$                             | Raw accelerometer readings (tangential, radial axes)    |
| $\theta_{b,\text{accel}}$              | Instantaneous accelerometer-only tilt estimate          |
| $\dot{\theta}_{b,\text{gyro}}$         | Raw gyro rate measurement                               |
| $\gamma$                               | Complementary-filter weight (accelerometer term)        |
| $\Delta t$                             | Control/estimation loop sample period                   |
| $x_f, \alpha$                          | Offset-correction filter state, filter coefficient      |
| $d$                                    | Constant tilt-sensor offset                             |
| $\theta_{\text{th}}$                   | Tilt threshold, jump-up $\rightarrow$ balancing switch  |
| $K_d^{(i)}$                            | Scheduled gain at linearisation point $i$ (extension)   |

## 7.2 Gain Scheduling and Mode Transitions

The controller switches from the open-loop jump-up sequence to the LQR law once  $|\hat{\theta}_b| < \theta_{\text{th}}$ , with hysteresis around  $\theta_{\text{th}}$  to prevent mode chattering. The baseline uses a single fixed gain  $K_d$  at the upright equilibrium. If recovery degrades near the edges of the operating range, where the small-angle linearisation weakens, gain scheduling will be added: additional gains  $K_d^{(i)}$  computed at several linearisation points, with the controller interpolating between them based on  $\hat{\theta}_b$ , reusing the same discrete structure and offset filter. The mode-transition logic gains a third mode for the 3D cube, Edge-to-Corner jump-up, triggered once edge balancing is stable, followed by a second threshold switch into the corner LQR once estimated orientation nears corner-up; the full state machine is given in Table 21.

## 7.3 Pure LQR Control Logic

Section 7.1 derives  $K_d$  offline, once, from the linear model. What actually executes on the flight computer every control tick is the sequence below, stated independent of how  $K_d$  was computed so that the running controller can be read, checked and re-implemented without re-deriving the gain. Table 19 (2D) and its 3D counterpart of Section 3.4 define every symbol used; the fully detailed pseudocode, including the supervisory state machine, is in Appendix D.

1. **Sense.** Read raw gyro rate  $\dot{\theta}_{b,\text{gyro}}$  and accelerometer  $(a_x, a_y)$  from the IMU over SPI; read wheel angle(s) from the encoder(s) over the moteus CAN reply.
2. **Estimate tilt.** Form the accelerometer-only estimate  $\theta_{b,\text{accel}}[k] = \tan^{-1}(-a_x[k]/a_y[k])$  and fuse it with gyro integration through the complementary filter of Eq. (14) to obtain  $\hat{\theta}_b[k]$ .
3. **Remove offset.** Update the low-pass offset state  $x_f[k]$  (Eq. (15)) and subtract it from  $\hat{\theta}_b[k]$ .

4. **Assemble the state.** Build  $\hat{x}[k] = (\hat{\theta}_b[k] - x_f[k], \hat{\theta}_b[k], \hat{\theta}_w[k])$  in 2D, or the 9-vector  $(\theta, \omega_b, \omega_w)$  of Section 3.4 in 3D.
5. **Check the mode.** If the supervisory state machine (Table 21) is not in a balancing mode, skip to step 8 and issue that mode's own open-loop command instead of  $u[k]$  below.
6. **Compute the command.**  $u[k] = -K_d \hat{x}[k]$ .
7. **Saturate and manage momentum.** Clip  $u[k]$  to the driver's continuous current rating (Appendix A); if a wheel speed  $\hat{\theta}_w$  exceeds its desaturation threshold, add a small bias torque directed to bleed the stored momentum without materially perturbing  $\hat{\theta}_b$ .
8. **Actuate.** Issue  $u[k]$  (or the mode's open-loop command) as a CAN-FD torque request to each moteus driver.
9. **Advance.**  $k \leftarrow k + 1$ ; repeat at the next 1 kHz tick (Section 7.5.1).

This is the loop exercised in simulation (Section 7.4) before it is exercised on hardware, and it is the loop whose worst-case timing is bounded by construction in Section 7.5.1.

## 7.4 Simulation Environment: Simulink/Simscape Multibody

The control law of Sections 7.1–7.3 is validated in simulation before any closed-loop hardware run, on a plant built from the same CAD geometry as the physical prototypes rather than from the lumped-parameter equations alone — so that the simulation catches geometry effects (asymmetric mass distribution, off-axis clearances) the analytic model cannot represent.

**CAD-to-Simscape workflow.** Each CAD assembly — the 1-DoF rig of Section 5.1.2 and the 3D cube of Section 5.1 — is exported as a STEP assembly and imported into Simscape Multibody, which converts each part and mate into a rigid body and joint in a multibody tree. The pivot bearing of the 1-DoF rig and the corner/edge contact features of the 3D cube are modelled as the corresponding revolute/point-contact joints, so that the simulated degrees of freedom match Sections 3.2 and 3.4 exactly rather than approximating them. Per-part mass and inertia are taken directly from the CAD model, which is the same convention that makes the mass roll-up of Section 5.1.1 auditable: the simulation, the sizing, and the fabricated part all trace to one model.

**Actuation and sensing blocks.** Each motor is represented as a torque source at its joint, saturated and rate-limited to the envelope of Section 6; the brake is a discrete event that zeroes the relevant wheel-body relative velocity over the  $\Delta t$  of Equation (11). Simulated IMU and encoder blocks apply noise and bias models set from the sensors' characterised behaviour once measured on hardware, so that the same estimator and control logic of Section 7.3 — not a re-implementation of it — runs against simulated sensor data in a controller-in-the-loop configuration before it runs against real sensors.

**Test cases.** Three cases are run against the LQR baseline: recovery from an initial tilt offset, which establishes the region of attraction; rejection of an impulse disturbance applied at the body, which is the simulated counterpart of the disturbance-recovery criterion the hardware is later judged against; and behaviour under wheel-speed saturation, which exercises the momentum-dumping step of Section 7.3 and is the case most likely to be missed by a purely linear analysis, since saturation is precisely where the linear model ceases to describe the plant. Each case is re-run with the plant parameters perturbed about their nominal values, by a magnitude set once the identification tolerances of Section 3.3 are measured, so that the gains are shown not to be

knife-edge: a gain set that stabilises only the nominal plant is not a result, because the nominal plant is not the one that will be built.

**Direction of validation.** The measured parameters of Section 3.3 are substituted into the plant and the gains re-derived before hardware balance is attempted; the simulation is validated against the measured plant, never the reverse. A discrepancy between simulated and measured closed-loop behaviour is treated as a finding about the model.

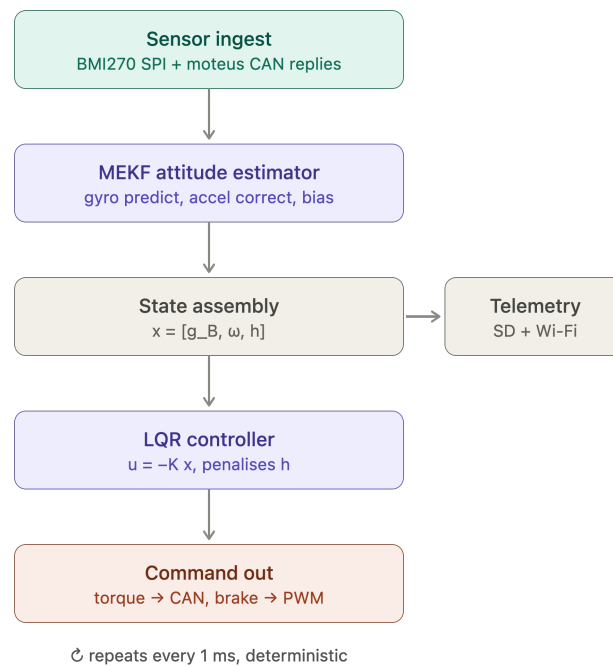
No Simulink/Simscape model or CAD export exists yet at the time of writing; this subsection states the workflow and the intended test cases, and is populated with the model, the exported geometry and the resulting response plots once built.

## 7.5 System Integration

### 7.5.1 Onboard Software Pipeline

The subsystems of Figure 8 are coordinated by a single deterministic task on the Teensy, whose structure is given in Figure 11. Each 1 ms cycle executes the same fixed sequence: sensor ingest reads the BMI270 over SPI and the moteus replies over CAN; the MEKF propagates attitude on the gyro and corrects it against the accelerometer while estimating gyro bias; the state vector  $x = [g_B, \omega, h]$  is assembled from the estimator output and the wheel speeds; the LQR law of Section 7.1 evaluates  $u = -Kx$  with a penalty on stored momentum  $h$  to bleed off wheel saturation; and the resulting commands leave as CAN torque requests to the drivers and a PWM signal to the brake servos. Telemetry is tapped off the assembled state to SD and Wi-Fi outside the control path, so logging cannot perturb loop timing.

The fixed ordering matters: with no dynamic allocation and no blocking calls, the worst-case cycle time is bounded by construction rather than measured after the fact, which is what makes the 1 kHz sample period of the discrete LQR design a design guarantee rather than an average.



**Figure 11:** Teensy 4.1 control-loop software pipeline. The estimator and controller stages implement the design of Section 7.1; telemetry is a side-branch off the control path.

### 7.5.2 Control Software Architecture

Sections 7.1–7.3 derive the control law and its executable logic; this subsection states how that law is realised as software, which is a separate set of decisions. The implementation detail — the mode state machine, the estimator and controller in executable pseudocode, the fixed gains and tuning parameters, the timing budget and the fault responses — is collected in Appendix D, so that a re-tuned gain does not require an edit to the design sections.

The software is organised in the four layers of Table 20. The division is not stylistic: each layer has a different failure mode and a different verification method, and the interfaces between them are what allow the controller validated in simulation (Section 7.4) to be the same code that runs on the cube.

**Table 20:** Control software layers. Each is verified by a different method, which is why the boundaries are held.

| Layer                | Responsibility                                              | Verified by                                              |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Hardware abstraction | Sensor and driver I/O, timing, bus transactions             | Bench read-back; loop-timing measurement                 |
| Estimation           | Attitude and rate estimate from IMU and encoders (Sec. 7.1) | Static and dynamic bench tests against a known reference |
| Control              | State feedback, momentum management, saturation handling    | Simulation on the identified model, then hardware        |
| Supervision          | Mode transitions, arming, watchdog and fault response       | Fault-injection tests on the rig                         |

**Operating modes.** The supervisory layer sequences the modes of Table 21, with hysteresis on every threshold to prevent chattering at a boundary, and with a disarm transition available from every mode. The modes are specified as a state machine because the critical transitions are the descending ones: a fall detected during corner balance must reach a safe state with the wheels commanded down, not merely switch to a different gain.

**Table 21:** Operating modes and transitions. Every mode has a disarm exit.

| Mode            | Behaviour                                           | Exit condition                              |
|-----------------|-----------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| Idle / disarmed | Drivers de-energised; sensors and telemetry live    | Explicit arm command                        |
| Wheel spin-up   | Open-loop speed ramp to the jump-up momentum target | Target wheel speed reached                  |
| Jump-up         | Brake actuation and momentum transfer (Sec. 4.1)    | Tilt inside the balancing capture band      |
| Edge balance    | Single-axis state feedback (Sec. 7.1)               | Corner-transition command, or fall detected |
| Corner balance  | Three-axis state feedback (Sec. 3.4)                | Slew command, or fall detected              |
| Slew / rotation | Reference tracking between equilibria               | Reference reached; revert to balance        |
| Fault / safe    | Wheels commanded down, drivers disarmed             | Manual reset                                |

**Real-time guarantees.** The loop-rate claim of Section 7.1 is a design guarantee only if the worst-case cycle is bounded by construction, which is why the pipeline of Figure 11 uses a fixed

stage ordering with no dynamic allocation and no blocking calls, and why telemetry is a side-branch rather than a stage.

**Fault handling.** The failure cases the software must survive are sensor dropout, bus error, wheel saturation and loss of the balancing equilibrium. The first three have defined responses that keep the machine controlled; the fourth is a controlled shutdown rather than a recovery attempt, since a cube that has left its capture region cannot be recovered by the linear law and continued actuation only adds energy to the fall.



## 8 Results

### 8.1 Validation Results to Date

This subsection reports evidence against the validation stages of Section ?? and the acceptance criteria of Table 1, in the order the stages are entered. Where no result exists yet, the criterion is stated so the gap is explicit rather than silent.

#### 8.1.1 1-DoF Control Validation

The single-axis rig is the protected experimental item of Section 2.3, and its balance result is the evidence carried into this document. Gate G3 requires the rig to balance for at least 60 s unassisted.

Beyond the duration criterion, three quantities are recorded because they determine whether the result transfers to the integrated cube rather than merely holding on the rig. Recovery from a defined impulse establishes that the balance is a stabilised equilibrium and not a fortunate initial condition. Steady-state wheel-speed drift measures momentum accumulation: a controller that balances while monotonically spinning up is one that will saturate, and the drift rate predicts when. Control effort is compared against the continuous and peak current limits of the driver given in Appendix A, since a balance sustained only by exceeding the continuous rating is not a balance that survives to the demonstration.

#### 8.1.2 3-DoF Control Validation

For the 3D model, control-loop validation to date has achieved edge balance on the final prototype using the 1-DoF control law; corner balance has not yet been demonstrated. **TODO: results comparing edge-balance duration, disturbance recovery and control effort against the acceptance criteria of Table 1 and the 1-DoF bench results of Section 8.1.1.**

## 9 Conclusions & Next Steps

### 9.1 Conclusions

The team has demonstrated the ability to build and control the Cubli across the planned difficulty progression: a working 1-DoF model, and edge balance on the final 3D prototype, both achieved through the staged validation approach described in this document. Several of the originally planned tasks have been rescheduled in response to deadline pressure and issues encountered along the way, but the team has continued to make progress toward the final objective. Corner balance remains the outstanding milestone and is expected to be resolved in the days before final delivery and presentation. Cubli has confirmed itself to be a tightly coupled, multidisciplinary system: reliably building and controlling it depends on close coordination and continuous communication across the team's subsystem interfaces.

### 9.2 AI-Driven Control & Dynamic Coefficient Tuning

#### 9.2.1 Motivation: Limitations of a Fixed Gain

The balancing controller of Section 7.1 computes a single gain  $K_d$  offline, from an  $(A, B)$  pair built from the parameters of Tables 5 and 8. That gain is optimal for exactly one plant: the one those numbers describe. It is retained here as the baseline precisely because it is simple and verifiable, but its optimality is conditional in three ways that the hardware of this project is expected to violate.

- **Parametric drift.**  $C_b$  and  $C_w$  are not obtained from CAD and are carried as estimates until the identification tests of Table 6. Bearing friction, wiring drag and motor cogging also change with temperature, wear and reassembly, so the identified values are a snapshot rather than a constant. The inertia tensor  $I$  and the centre-of-mass offset  $r_{cm}$  are subject to the same objection at the few-percent level, and  $r_{cm}$  in particular shifts whenever the pack or harness is disturbed.
- **Payload and configuration changes.** Any added mass changes  $m$ ,  $r_{cm}$  and  $I$  simultaneously, and therefore changes  $A$ . A gain tuned for one configuration is not merely suboptimal for another; near a fully unstable equilibrium it may be destabilising.
- **Contact and surface variation.** The pivot is modelled as an ideal frictionless point or line. A real corner resting on a real surface slips, deforms and dissipates energy in a way that is neither in the model nor constant across surfaces, and this is the dominant unmodelled effect for the walking objective of Section 1.3.

The standard remedy within the existing design is gain scheduling on  $\hat{\theta}_b$  (Section 7.1), but scheduling interpolates between gains that were themselves computed from the same assumed parameters. It addresses the weakening of the small-angle linearisation; it does not address a plant that differs from the model. The proposal here is to keep the verified feedback law and adapt its coefficients online.

#### 9.2.2 Proposed Hybrid Architecture

The intended structure is deliberately conservative: a classical inner loop whose stability properties are understood, wrapped by a slow outer loop that adjusts the inner loop's coefficients. Writing  $\phi$  for the tunable coefficient vector,

$$u[k] = -K_d(\phi[k])\hat{x}[k], \quad \phi[k+1] = \phi[k] + \Delta\phi(\hat{x}[k], \hat{x}[k-1], \dots), \quad (17)$$

where  $\hat{x}$  is the estimated state of Section 7.1 and  $\Delta\phi$  is produced by the tuner. Two properties of (17) matter more than the choice of learning algorithm. First, the inner loop remains a linear

state feedback at every instant, so the controller that runs on the hardware is the one already implemented and tested. Second,  $\phi$  is updated on a timescale far slower than the control period  $\Delta t$ , which keeps the frozen-gain analysis approximately valid and prevents the tuner from acting as an unmodelled fast feedback path. Three candidate tuners are of interest, and they are not equivalent in cost:

- **Bayesian optimisation** over a low-dimensional parameterization of  $Q$  and  $R$ , minimising a measured cost from short balancing trials [7]. This is the cheapest option and the one with a direct precedent on this class of hardware: automatic LQR tuning has been demonstrated on an inverted pendulum with on the order of tens of experiments [8], and a self-tuning LQR has been run on the Cubli's own ancestor platform at ETH [9]. It tunes between trials, not within them.
- **Adaptive dynamic programming**, which solves the LQR problem online from measured data rather than from  $(A, B)$ , converging toward the optimal gain for the true plant without an explicit model [10]. This is the option with the strongest theoretical guarantees and the strictest excitation requirements.
- **Reinforcement learning**, in which a policy trained in simulation outputs  $\Delta\phi$  continuously from the state-error history. This is the most capable and the least verifiable, and is treated below as the exploratory branch rather than the default.

**Deployment reservations.** The literature supporting learned control is overwhelmingly validated in simulation or on well-instrumented hardware, and the failure mode of an online tuner on an open-loop-unstable plant is a fall, not a degraded score. Any deployment on this cube should therefore be gated behind: a projection of  $\phi$  onto a set for which the frozen-gain closed loop is verified stable across the parameter uncertainty; a fallback to the fixed  $K_d$  of Section 7.1 on any estimator fault or divergence; and bench trials with the cube tethered. This is future work in the literal sense — none of it is a committed deliverable of the present design, and the baseline controller is not contingent on any of it.

### 9.2.3 Module 1: Dynamic Gain Tuning

The tuner does not emit motor currents. It emits the coefficients from which  $K_d$  is computed, which bounds what a bad update can do. Two parameterizations are worth comparing:

- **Weight-space tuning.** The policy outputs the diagonal entries of the cost matrices,  $\phi = (\log q_1, \dots, \log q_9, \log r_1, \log r_2, \log r_3)$  with  $Q = \text{diag}(q_i) \succ 0$  and  $R = \text{diag}(r_i) \succ 0$ , and  $K_d$  follows from the discrete algebraic Riccati equation. The logarithmic parameterization enforces positive definiteness by construction, so every  $\phi$  the policy can emit corresponds to a well-posed LQR problem and, for a stabilisable  $(A_d, B_d)$ , to a stabilising gain for the *modelled* plant. The cost is that a Riccati solve must run onboard whenever  $\phi$  changes, which is what confines updates to a slow outer loop.
- **Gain-space tuning.** The policy perturbs the entries of  $K_d$  directly, or equivalently the  $K_p, K_d$  pair of a PD form, avoiding the Riccati solve at the price of losing the structural guarantee above. This is the practical choice if the outer loop must run fast, and it makes the projection step of the previous paragraph mandatory rather than merely prudent.

For the 3D corner-balancing case the state is  $x = (\theta, \omega_b, \omega_w) \in \mathbb{R}^9$  and  $K_d$  is  $3 \times 9$  (Section 3.4), so tuning the 54 free entries directly is not sensible on the available data. Weight-space tuning reduces the problem to 12 coefficients, and symmetry of the three wheel axes reduces it further if the wheels are treated as identical. A reward or cost of the form

$$c[k] = \hat{x}^T[k] W_x \hat{x}[k] + \rho \|u[k]\|^2 + \sigma \|\omega_w[k]\|^2 \quad (18)$$

adds an explicit penalty on stored wheel momentum, which the nominal LQR cost  $J(u)$  of Section 7.1 does not distinguish from any other state deviation. This term is the one directly relevant to the saturation problem raised in Section 1.2: it expresses a preference for holding attitude with the wheels near zero speed, leaving momentum headroom for disturbance rejection.

#### 9.2.4 Module 2: Sim-to-Real Transfer via Domain Randomization

A policy trained against a single nominal parameter set learns to exploit that parameter set. Domain randomization instead samples the plant parameters from a distribution at the start of each training episode [11], so that the policy is optimised against a family of plants rather than one, and the transfer method has a substantial record on physical legged hardware [12]. For this cube the randomized quantities follow directly from the identification gaps already documented:

- **Damping:**  $C_b, C_w$  over a wide interval, since these are estimated rather than measured until the identification of Section 3.3 closes.
- **Inertia and mass distribution:**  $I, m$  and  $r_{cm}$  perturbed by a few percent, covering print-density variation, fastener placement and harness routing.
- **Actuation:**  $K_m$  within motor tolerance, plus a current saturation limit and a commanded-torque delay, so the policy cannot assume an ideal actuator.
- **Contact:** pivot friction and restitution, and a small random ground slope — the term standing in for the surface variation that motivates this module.
- **Sensing:** gyro bias walk, accelerometer noise and an injected vibration component, matching the estimator degradation identified in Section 1.1 as the practical limit on balancing.

The sensing term requires particular care. The accelerometer corruption on this platform is generated by the controller’s own wheel activity, so it is correlated with the policy’s actions rather than independent of them. A randomization scheme that injects only white sensor noise will understate the difficulty, and a policy that transfers under it should not be assumed to transfer on hardware. Whether the randomized distribution covers the real cube is an empirical question, settled by bench testing; the principal failure mode of this module is a distribution selected for convenience rather than representativeness.

#### 9.2.5 Module 3: Jump-Up Energy Optimisation

The jump-up analysis of Section 4.1.1 treats the manoeuvre as a spin-up to  $\omega_{\max}$  followed by an abrupt stop, with all deviation from the ideal absorbed into a single brake-amplification factor  $\beta = \tau_b/(\tau_b - \tau_g)$ . That model is adequate for sizing and is deliberately conservative, but it is a poor description of what the mechanism does: the servo-driven barrier has finite travel, the collision is not instantaneous, and the resulting torque profile is neither a step nor known in advance.

The proposal is to treat the torque command over the manoeuvre window as a profile to be optimised rather than a constant. Parameterizing the pre-brake and post-impact torque commands by a small vector  $\psi$  — for instance the timing of brake release relative to the wheel-speed trajectory, and the shape of the recovery torque applied by the remaining wheels immediately after impact — the objective is

$$\min_{\psi} \mathbb{E} \left[ \|\theta(t_f) - \theta^*\|^2 + \mu \|\omega_b(t_f)\|^2 \right] \quad \text{subject to} \quad \omega_w \leq \omega_{\max}, \quad |u_i| \leq u_{\max}, \quad (19)$$

where  $t_f$  is the instant the controller hands over to the balancing law at  $|\hat{\theta}_b| < \theta_{th}$ . Minimising residual body rate at handover is the quantity of interest, because a jump that reaches the equilibrium with excess rate demands recovery authority the balancing controller may not have.

Because each evaluation of (19) is a physical jump, the sample budget is small and the appropriate method is Bayesian optimisation rather than a policy-gradient method, with the initial design taken from the analytical  $h_w$  of Equation (9).

Two constraints on this module must be stated. First, it presupposes the measurement described in Section 4.1.1: until the spin-down test reports both the impulse-equivalent mean  $\bar{\tau}_b = h_w/\Delta t$  and the peak torque, there is no validated model to optimise against and no way to distinguish an improved profile from a mis-measured one. Second, the structural caveat carries over unchanged — optimisation must not be permitted to search toward shorter stopping times, since  $\tau_b$  is simultaneously a load on the barrier, bolt, bracket and spokes, and the sizing value was chosen for the dynamics and not for that load path. The search space must be bounded by the structural case, not by the dynamic one.

### 9.2.6 Relevance Beyond the Bench

Two application claims follow, and both are narrower than the general enthusiasm for learned control would suggest.

For **CubeSat attitude control**, the relevant fact is that a spacecraft’s inertia tensor is known imprecisely at integration and changes in flight — propellant depletion, deployable appendages, thermal distortion — while reaction-wheel friction rises with bearing age. These are the orbital analogues of the parametric drift of Section 7.1, and they are conventionally handled by conservative fixed gains with margin, at a cost in pointing performance. A tuner that adapts  $Q$  and  $R$  against measured performance addresses exactly this gap. The qualification barrier for flying learned control is high and unaddressed here; the architecture of (17) is chosen partly because a bounded outer loop over a classical inner loop is the form most likely to survive that scrutiny.

For **low-gravity surface mobility**, the case is stronger, because the plant is genuinely unknown before arrival. Regolith mechanical properties on a small body are not characterised to the precision a hopping controller would want, and the flight-proven hoppers cited in Section 1.2 [4, 5] move ballistically rather than under closed-loop control for this reason. The contact randomization of Module 2 and the profile optimisation of Module 3 map onto that problem directly: a hop whose landing attitude is controlled, on a surface whose properties were sampled from a distribution rather than assumed, is the capability that separates directional walking from a ballistic tumble [6]. The cube tests this under 1 g, where the destabilising torque is larger and never relents — a harder case in that one respect, as argued in Section 1.2, though it does not reproduce the low-gravity contact dynamics that would decide the real manoeuvre.

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## A Bill of Materials

The components supplied for this project constitute an *electronics* bill of materials: the actuation chain, wheel and attitude sensing, on-board compute, communications and power distribution are specified, but no structural or mechanical hardware is. The reaction wheels, the frame, the motor mounts, the fasteners and every printed bracket are the team’s design responsibility, and are treated as such in Section 5. Table 22 lists the supplied items grouped by subsystem. The actuation figures derived from these parts — the torque constant, the achievable torque and wheel speed, and the inertia that sizes the wheel — are developed where they are used, in Sections 4.1.1 and 4.3.

The architecture the BOM implies is a two-level control stack: each mjbots moteus-n1 closes a high-rate field-oriented current loop on its motor, using the MA600 encoder for rotor angle, while the Teensy 4.1 runs the outer attitude-estimation and state-feedback loop over CAN-FD — the same inner-tachometer / outer-attitude layering used in spacecraft reaction-wheel assemblies. A mechanical wheel brake, following the original ETH Cubli [2], provides the near-impulsive momentum transfer required for the jump-up.

Procurement is the single largest schedule risk. The long-lead items are not electronic but mechanical: the frame stock and the printed structure gate the entire build, and with three actuation sets and no spare, the loss of a motor or driver in service would force the reduced-actuation one-wheel variant [13]. These items are ordered first. Consumables and bench equipment not covered by the supplied set — wire, connectors, fasteners, filament, the current-limited bench supply and the battery-safety kit — are tracked separately in the build documentation.

**Table 22:** Supplied bill of materials, grouped by subsystem.

| Ref                               | Item                                      | Qty <sup>a</sup> | Key specifications                                                                                                | Function                                       |
|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Actuation</b>                  |                                           |                  |                                                                                                                   |                                                |
| 1                                 | T-Motor<br>MN4006 KV380                   | 3                | 18N24P outrunner; 380 rpm/V;<br>68 g; $\varnothing 44.35$ mm $\times$ 21 mm; 194 m $\Omega$ ;<br>peak 16 A, 380 W | Reaction-wheel torque<br>source                |
| 2                                 | mjbots moteus-<br>n1                      | 3                | 10–54 V; 100 A peak / 9 A cont.;<br>15–30 kHz FOC; 5 Mbit/s CAN-<br>FD; 14.6 g                                    | FOC current/torque<br>driver (inner loop)      |
| 11                                | TowerPro<br>MG92B servo                   | 3                | metal-gear micro servo; $\approx 0.29$ N m<br>( $\approx 3$ kg cm) at 6 V; 50 Hz PWM                              | Wheel brake actuator<br>(jump-up)              |
| <b>Sensing</b>                    |                                           |                  |                                                                                                                   |                                                |
| 3                                 | mjbots MA600<br>breakout + ring<br>magnet | 3                | TMR absolute angle; SPI 6 MHz,<br>3.3 V; 16-bit (65,536 counts/rev);<br>air-gap $\leq 0.5$ mm                     | Wheel angle: commuta-<br>tion + state feedback |
| 10                                | SparkFun<br>BMI270 6-DoF<br>IMU           | 1                | 3-axis accel + 3-axis gyro (no<br>magnetometer); I <sup>2</sup> C 400 kHz<br>(Qwiic); ODR up to $\approx 1$ kHz   | Body attitude reference<br>(tilt + rates)      |
| <b>Compute and Communications</b> |                                           |                  |                                                                                                                   |                                                |
| 4                                 | Teensy 4.1                                | 1                | 600 MHz Cortex-M7 + FPU; na-<br>tive CAN-FD (CAN3); 5 V supply                                                    | Flight computer: esti-<br>mator + control law  |
| 5                                 | CAN-FD<br>adapter (Teensy<br>4.1)         | 1                | CAN-FD transceiver, logic-level $\rightarrow$<br>differential; 5 Mbit/s                                           | Bus transceiver for the<br>MCU                 |

*Continued on next page*

Table 22 (continued)

| Ref                | Item                                   | Qty <sup>a</sup> | Key specifications                                                       | Function                                   |
|--------------------|----------------------------------------|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| 6                  | mjbots<br>mjcanfd-usb-<br>1x           | 1                | USB ↔ CAN-FD, 5 Mbit/s                                                   | Bench interface (cali-<br>bration, tuning) |
| 7                  | JST-PH3 CAN<br>cables                  | ≥4               | 2 A AC/DC; 3-conductor daisy-<br>chain                                   | CAN bus interconnect                       |
| 8                  | Seeed XIAO<br>ESP32-C6 +<br>antenna    | 1                | Wi-Fi; 3.3 V UART to MCU; TX<br>burst ≈ 300 mA                           | Wi-Fi telemetry / com-<br>mand link        |
| 9                  | 60.4 Ω 0.5 W<br>resistor               | 4                | Split termination, $2 \times 60.4 \Omega \approx$<br>120 Ω bus impedance | CAN bus termination                        |
| 17                 | 4.7 nF capacitor                       | 2                | common-mode filter, bus midpoint<br>to ground                            | CAN split-termination<br>filter            |
| <b>Power</b>       |                                        |                  |                                                                          |                                            |
| 12                 | Tattu R-Line<br>V5.0 6S LiPo<br>(XT60) | 1                | 22.2 V; 1550 mA h; 150C;<br>≈ 35 W h; ≈ 254 g                            | Primary energy store                       |
| 13                 | LM2596 buck<br>module                  | 1                | step-down to 5.0 V; rated 2–3 A<br>(derates without heatsink)            | 5 V logic rail                             |
| 14                 | XT60 connector<br>pair                 | 1–2              | rated ≈ 60 A                                                             | Battery power connec-<br>tor               |
| 15                 | 100 μF 16 V<br>electrolytic            | 2–4              | 16 V part — 5 V rail only                                                | 5 V-rail bulk reservoir                    |
| 19                 | 1N5819 Schot-<br>tky diode             | 1–2              | 1 A, 40 V                                                                | 5 V-rail back-feed pro-<br>tection         |
| <b>Integration</b> |                                        |                  |                                                                          |                                            |
| 16                 | 100 nF 50 V<br>capacitor               | 6–10             | local decoupling at each IC                                              | Per-IC supply decou-<br>pling              |
| 18                 | Double-sided<br>perfboard              | 1                | 15 cm × 9 cm, double-sided                                               | Power / signal distribu-<br>tion board     |

<sup>a</sup> Quantity per assembled cube; motors, drivers, encoders and brake servos are 3 each — one per wheel axis.



## B CAD and Construction Detail

This appendix holds the mechanical detail deliberately kept out of Section 5.1: the model tree, the drawing set, the fabrication settings and the assembly sequence. The rationale for the architecture — why the frame is split, what fixes the envelope, how the wheel is tuned — stays in Section 5.1 and is not repeated here. Anything in this appendix may change without the design intent changing; anything in Section 5.1 may not.

### B.1 Design Parameter Table

Table 23 is the single source of the driving dimensions referenced by every part in the model, per convention 1 of Section 5.1.1. It is the CAD-side mirror of the envelope closure of Section 4.2 and is updated on each iteration.

**Table 23:** Driving CAD parameters. Every dependent feature references these; no part carries a duplicated hard-coded value.

| Symbol     | Parameter                                  | Value  |
|------------|--------------------------------------------|--------|
| $L$        | Cube edge length (outer)                   | 15 cm  |
| $t_w$      | Frame wall thickness                       | 5 mm   |
| $D_w$      | Wheel outer diameter (Sec. 4.3)            | 120 mm |
| $t_r$      | Wheel axial thickness (Sec. 4.3)           | 5 mm   |
| $d_m$      | Motor axis offset from cube centre         | TBD    |
| $h_m$      | Motor mounting face height on its axis     | TBD    |
| $c_w$      | Wheel-to-subframe axial clearance          | TBD    |
| $c_o$      | Clearance between orthogonal wheel modules | TBD    |
| $V_{\min}$ | Minimum internal clear volume              | TBD    |
| $r_c$      | Corner contact feature radius              | TBD    |

### B.2 Model Tree and Part List

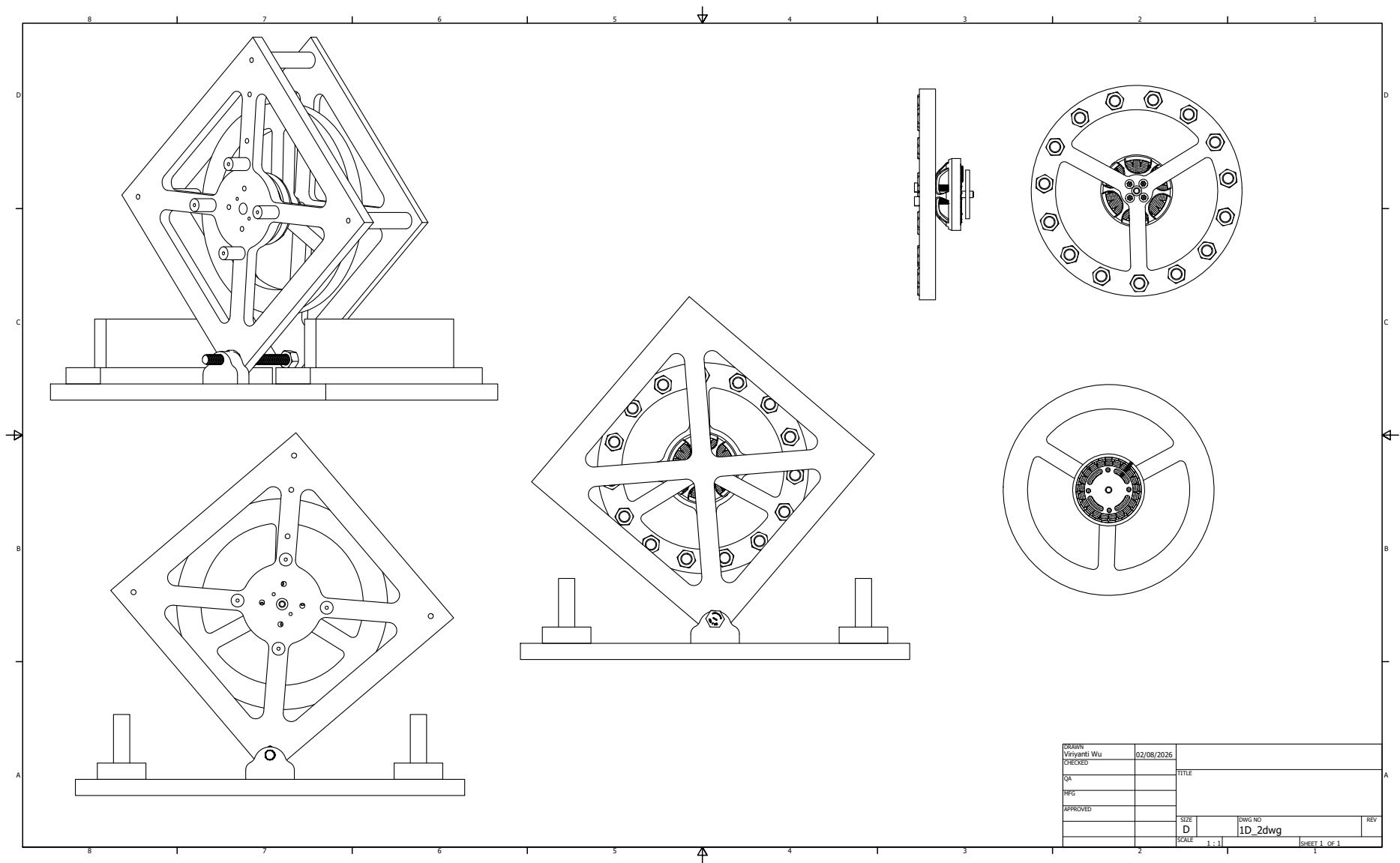
Table 24 lists the modelled parts by assembly, with their fabrication route and current status. It is the mechanical counterpart to the electronics bill of materials of Appendix A: the parts here are the team’s design responsibility and are not supplied.

### B.3 1-DoF Prototype Construction

The general-assembly drawing of the 1-DoF rig is given in Figure 12. This is the final released design of the single-axis prototype: the sheet carries the orthographic set — front and side elevations of the rig on its base, and a plan and edge view of the reaction-wheel assembly — from which the plate geometry, the pivot bearing seat, the motor bolt circle and the hard-stop placement are taken. The rig as built from this drawing is shown in Figure 6.

**Table 24:** CAD model tree and part list. Quantities are per assembled cube unless noted; the 1-DoF rig parts are listed separately.

| Ref                            | Part                                          | Qty | Fabrication route | Status |
|--------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|-----|-------------------|--------|
| <b>Inner structure</b>         |                                               |     |                   |        |
| M1                             | Motor subframe                                | TBD | TBD               | TBD    |
| M2                             | Motor mount ( $\times$ axis)                  | 3   | TBD               | TBD    |
| M3                             | Battery cradle / retention                    | 1   | TBD               | TBD    |
| M4                             | Electronics tray                              | 1   | TBD               | TBD    |
| M5                             | Brake servo bracket                           | 3   | TBD               | TBD    |
| <b>Reaction wheel assembly</b> |                                               |     |                   |        |
| W1                             | Ballasted ring (Sec. 4.3)                     | 3   | TBD               | TBD    |
| W2                             | Wheel hub / rotor adapter                     | 3   | TBD               | TBD    |
| W3                             | Ballast bolt and nut set (M6, $3 \times 15$ ) | 45  | Standard hardware | TBD    |
| W4                             | Brake strike feature                          | 3   | TBD               | TBD    |
| <b>Outer frame</b>             |                                               |     |                   |        |
| F1                             | Frame member / edge rail                      | TBD | TBD               | TBD    |
| F2                             | Corner contact feature                        | 8   | TBD               | TBD    |
| F3                             | Face panel / wheel guard                      | TBD | TBD               | TBD    |
| <b>1-DoF rig (Sec. 5.1.2)</b>  |                                               |     |                   |        |
| R1                             | Face plate                                    | 1   | TBD               | TBD    |
| R2                             | Pivot bearing mount                           | 1   | TBD               | TBD    |
| R3                             | Rig motor mount                               | 1   | TBD               | TBD    |
| R4                             | Hard stops / containment                      | TBD | TBD               | TBD    |



**Figure 12:** General-assembly drawing of the 1-DoF prototype rig — the final released design of the single-axis article — sheet 1 of 1 at 1:1. Upper left and lower left: front elevation of the rig mounted on its base, showing the diagonal plate orientation, the corner pivot and the two hard stops. Centre: side elevation through the wheel axis. Right: plan and edge views of the reaction-wheel and motor assembly, giving the spoke pattern and the ballast bolt circle used for the balancing adjustment of Section 4.3.

## B.4 3D Cube Construction

The drawing set for the three-axis cube is not yet released. The frame has been realised so far as the concept prototype of Figure 7, which fixes the two-part architecture and the internal packaging but not the final dimensions: the edge length  $L$  and the wheel geometry close only once the sizing iteration of Section 4.3 converges on a confirmed motor. The drawings to be issued here on that closure are the inner-structure general assembly, the three motor modules on their orthogonal axes, the outer frame with its contact features, and a section view through two orthogonal wheel modules showing the clearances  $c_w$  and  $c_o$  of Table 23.

## B.5 Fabrication and Assembly

### B.5.1 Print and Manufacturing Settings

The printed parts are structural, not cosmetic: the wheel ring carries centrifugal load at the ballast holes and the motor mounts carry the brake impulse, which is the design load case identified in Section 1.1. Settings are therefore recorded per part in Table 25 and treated as part of the design, since a part reprinted at a different orientation or infill is not the part that was analysed.

**Table 25:** Fabrication settings for the structural printed parts. Layer orientation is specified relative to the principal load direction.

| Ref | Material | Infill / walls | Orientation and rationale |
|-----|----------|----------------|---------------------------|
| W1  | TBD      | TBD            | TBD                       |
| W2  | TBD      | TBD            | TBD                       |
| M1  | TBD      | TBD            | TBD                       |
| M2  | TBD      | TBD            | TBD                       |
| F1  | TBD      | TBD            | TBD                       |
| F2  | TBD      | TBD            | TBD                       |

### B.5.2 Assembly Sequence

The sequence of Table 26 is ordered by access: each step is one whose verification becomes impossible or destructive once a later step is complete. The encoder air gap in particular is re-checked after mechanical assembly, since it can shift when the structure is bolted up (Table 18).

## B.6 Mass Properties Verification

The CAD roll-up is an estimate until the assembly is weighed. Step 8 above closes the loop of Section 4.2: the measured mass is compared against the modelled value, and any discrepancy is carried back into  $I_{w,target}$  and absorbed, where possible, by the ballast trim of Section 4.3 rather than by a re-design.

**Table 26:** Assembly sequence. Ordering is set by access: each check must be completed before the step that encloses it.

| Step | Operation                                                      | Check before proceeding                           |
|------|----------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | Wheel assembly: ring, hub, ballast bolts to the selected count | Balance check; bolt retention per Sec. 4.3        |
| 2    | Motor to mount, encoder magnet to rotor                        | Encoder air gap and centring to the assembly spec |
| 3    | Motor modules to inner structure, three axes                   | Axis orthogonality; wheel clearance $c_w$ , $c_o$ |
| 4    | Battery and electronics tray into inner structure              | Pack centring; board keep-out clearances          |
| 5    | Harness install and dressing                                   | Continuity and isolation (Sec. 6.7)               |
| 6    | Inner structure into outer frame                               | Encoder air gaps re-checked after bolt-up         |
| 7    | Contact features and guards                                    | Contact geometry; wheel guard clearance           |
| 8    | Mass properties measurement                                    | Measured mass against Table 13                    |

**Table 27:** Modelled versus measured mass properties. A discrepancy here is absorbed by ballast trim where the margin allows.

| Quantity                    | CAD value | Measured | Discrepancy |
|-----------------------------|-----------|----------|-------------|
| Total cube mass $M$         | TBD       | TBD      | TBD         |
| Wheel mass $m_w$ (each)     | TBD       | TBD      | TBD         |
| Wheel inertia $I_w$ (each)  | TBD       | TBD      | TBD         |
| CoM offset from cube centre | TBD       | TBD      | TBD         |

## C Electrical System Detail

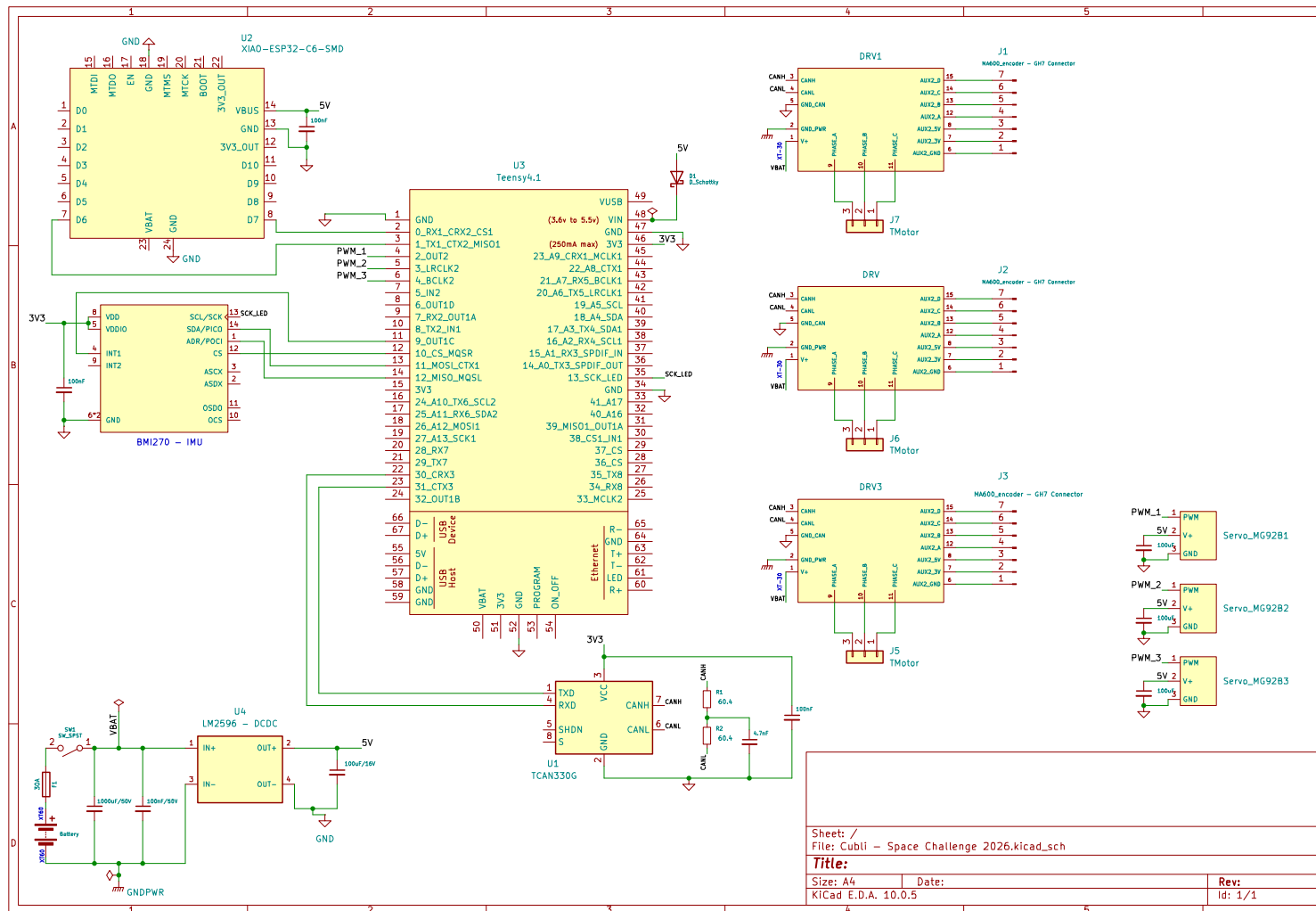
This appendix holds the electrical detail kept out of Section 6: the full schematic capture, the connector and pin assignments, the harness drawings, the board layout and the bring-up checklists. The architectural decisions — two rails behind one E-stop, linear bus topology, perfboard rather than fabricated board — remain in Section 6. The part specifications are in Appendix A and are not repeated.

### C.1 Schematic Capture

The system is captured on one flat KiCad sheet, reproduced at page size in Figure 20 and listed by functional block in Table 17. That capture is the working drawing the build is wired from. The blocks it carries are: power entry and protection (pack connector, anti-spark inrush path, combined E-stop and fuse, split to the motor bus and the logic rail); the 5 V logic rail off an LM2596 converter with back-feed protection and per-device decoupling; the CAN-FD bus as a linear chain across the three moteus drivers and the flight computer, terminated at the two physical ends only; the per-axis encoder SPI interfaces; the Teensy 4.1 flight computer with the BMI270 IMU; the ESP32 telemetry link; and the three brake servo drives.

Note: for the provided N35 1/4" × 1/8" diametric disk magnet, the optimal distance in order to achieve the 20 mT – 80 mT nominal magnetic field for the MA600 encoder is 3.3 mm.

Each block of the capture is checked against its governing constraint before bring-up: power entry and protection against the fuse rating and the inrush into the driver bulk capacitance; the 5 V logic rail against the converter rating and the worst-case rail total of Table 16; the CAN-FD bus against the linear-topology and termination rules of Table 18; the encoder interfaces against the SPI cable length limit and the 3.3 mm air gap; the flight computer and IMU against the sensor orientation and mounting location relative to the pivot required by Section 7; the telemetry link against its transmit-burst current and return path off the logic rail; and the brake servo drive against stall-current headroom on the logic rail, with its PWM routed clear of the encoder SPI. The full constraint table is given in Section 6.4 (Table 17) and is not repeated here.



**Figure 13:** Full electrical schematic as captured, reproduced at page size. Covers the flight computer (Teensy 4.1) and its ESP32 telemetry module, the BMI270 IMU, the three moteus driver and motor connectors, the CAN-FD transceiver and termination, the LM2596 5 V converter from the pack, and the three brake servos.

## C.2 Connector and Pin Assignments

Table 35 is the connector schedule. It exists so that a harness can be built and re-built from this document alone, and so that a mis-mate is a documented impossibility rather than a discovered one: no two connectors carrying different voltages share a housing type on this machine.

**Table 28:** Connector schedule. Keying and housing types are chosen so that two connectors carrying different voltages cannot be mated. Note: values have not been finalized at this preliminary stage.

| Ref | From               | To                    | Housing / keying | Signals                 |
|-----|--------------------|-----------------------|------------------|-------------------------|
| J1  | Battery pack       | Protection / E-stop   | TBD              | Pack +, pack –          |
| J2  | Protection         | Distribution board    | TBD              | Motor bus               |
| J3  | Distribution board | Driver, axis 1        | TBD              | Motor bus               |
| J4  | Distribution board | Driver, axis 2        | TBD              | Motor bus               |
| J5  | Distribution board | Driver, axis 3        | TBD              | Motor bus               |
| J6  | Board              | CAN chain, end A      | TBD              | CAN-H, CAN-L, GND       |
| J7  | CAN chain, end B   | Termination network   | TBD              | CAN-H, CAN-L, GND       |
| J8  | Driver, axis $i$   | Encoder, axis $i$     | TBD              | SPI, 3.3 V, GND         |
| J9  | Board              | IMU                   | TBD              | Serial bus, supply, GND |
| J10 | Board              | Telemetry module      | TBD              | UART, supply, GND       |
| J11 | Board              | Brake servo, axis $i$ | TBD              | PWM, 5 V, GND           |

## C.3 Harness Drawings and Wire Schedule

Table 36 is the wire schedule. Conductor gauge on the motor bus is set by the spin-up current rather than the balancing current, since spin-up is the sustained high-current phase; the signal runs are set by length limits rather than by current.

**Table 29:** Wire schedule. Motor-bus gauge is sized on spin-up current; signal runs are length-limited (Table 18). Note: values have not been finalized at this preliminary stage.

| Ref | Run                       | Gauge | Length | Sizing basis             |
|-----|---------------------------|-------|--------|--------------------------|
| H1  | Pack to protection        | TBD   | TBD    | Peak bus current         |
| H2  | Protection to board       | TBD   | TBD    | Peak bus current         |
| H3  | Board to driver drops (3) | TBD   | TBD    | Per-axis spin-up current |
| H4  | Motor phase leads (3)     | TBD   | TBD    | Motor phase current      |
| H5  | CAN chain segments        | TBD   | TBD    | Topology, not current    |
| H6  | Encoder SPI runs (3)      | TBD   | TBD    | Length limit governs     |
| H7  | Servo drives (3)          | TBD   | TBD    | Stall current            |

## C.4 Board Layout

The floorplan is constrained before it is aesthetic: the driver positions follow from the encoder cable limit, the bus route follows from the driver positions, and the board is placed around what remains (Section 6.5). Rail separation is maintained physically on the board, not only schematically, so that motor-current return does not share copper with the sensing ground.



## C.5 Bring-Up and Isolation Checklists

These checks are performed on every re-assembly, not only on first build, since the encoder gaps and connector seating are exactly what mechanical work disturbs.

### Before any power is applied.

1. Isolation: motor bus to chassis, logic rail to motor bus, each rail to ground.
2. Capacitor voltage ratings confirmed by position — no low-voltage part on the pack bus.
3. Polarity of every fabricated connector verified against Table 35.
4. Protection element in circuit: E-stop functional, fuse fitted and rated, anti-spark path intact.
5. Encoder air gaps re-measured after mechanical assembly.

### First power-on, current-limited bench supply.

1. Current limit verified against a known load before connecting the assembly.
2. Logic rail voltage and ripple under load; converter thermal check.
3. All drivers enumerate on the bus; encoders read back with no error flags; IMU responds.
4. Bus integrity at the full data rate: sustained soak with all nodes addressed, error-frame count logged.
5. Open-loop wheel motion, wheels contained, one axis at a time.

**First battery power-on.** Performed only after the bench sequence passes in full, with the pack protection verified, cell monitoring active and the assembly in a fire-safe area. Inrush is measured against the bulk capacitance on connection.

## C.6 As-Built Measurements

Table 37 records the measured electrical figures that replace the estimates used during design. These are the numbers reported back to the modelling and control work, and they are the reason the parameter identification of Section 3.3 runs on measured rather than assumed values.

**Table 30:** As-built electrical measurements. Each replaces an estimate used earlier in the design. Note: values have not been finalized at this preliminary stage.

| Quantity                              | Measured | Replaces / feeds             |
|---------------------------------------|----------|------------------------------|
| Motor torque constant $K_m$           | TBD      | Table 6, datasheet value     |
| Wheel inertia $I_w$ (spin-down)       | TBD      | Table 6, CAD value           |
| Viscous and Coulomb friction          | TBD      | $C_b$ , $C_w$ estimates      |
| Command-to-encoder latency            | TBD      | Loop timing, Sec. 7.5.2      |
| Achievable wheel speed on bus         | TBD      | $\omega_{\max}$ , Sec. 4.1.1 |
| Logic rail load, worst case           | TBD      | Table 16                     |
| Runtime per charge under balance load | TBD      | Demonstration planning       |

## D Control Algorithm Detail